

NĀṬYASĀSTRA GURUKULAM

CENTRE FOR CIVILISATIONAL STATECRAFT

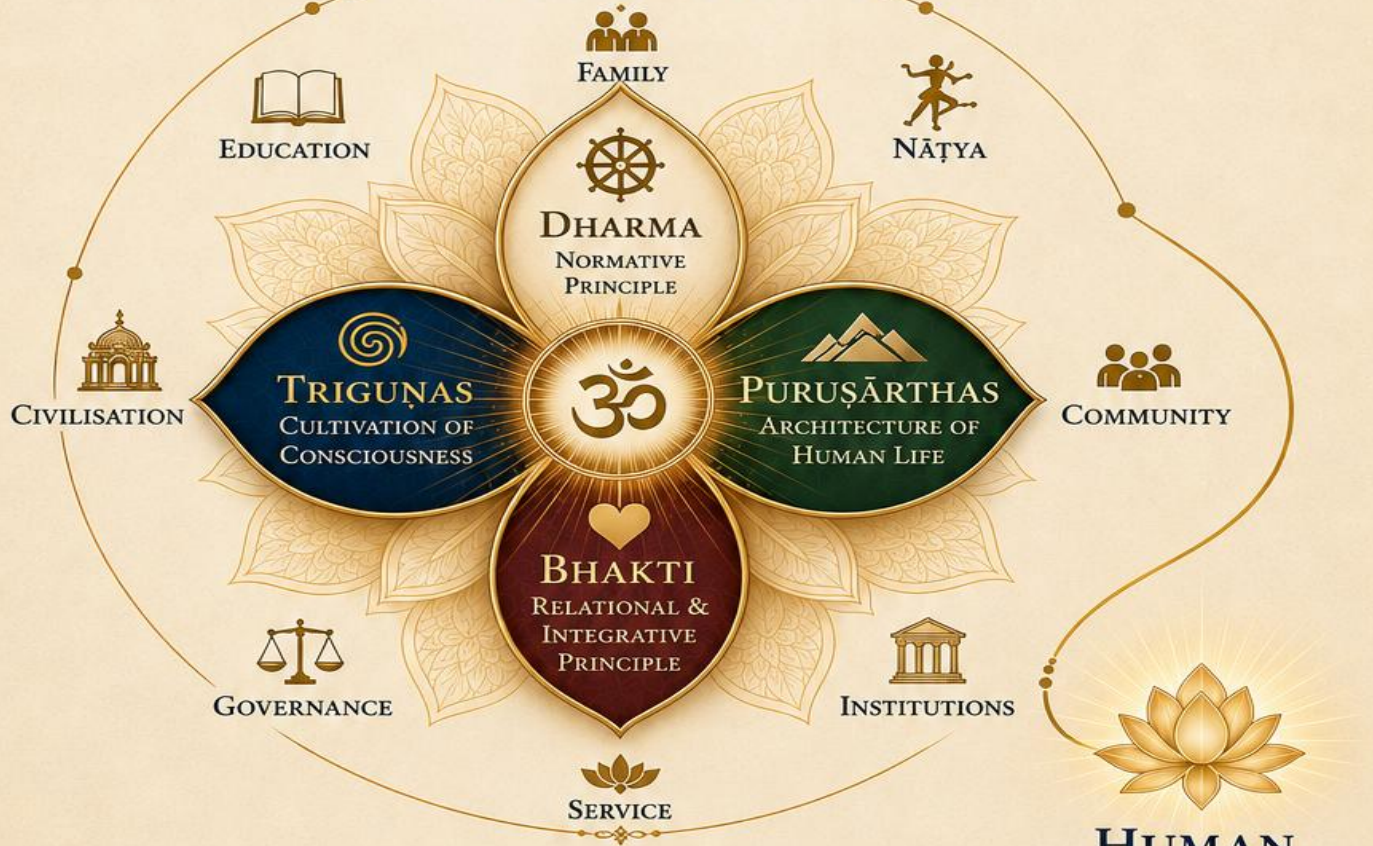
FLAGSHIP TREATISE

THE DHĀRMIC THEORY OF HUMAN FLOURISHING

A GENERATIVE ARCHITECTURE OF HUMAN FORMATION

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ROHIT VISWANATH

Yajamāna & Yojaka

Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam

Centre for Civilisational Statecraft

MARGA DARSHAK

PADMA BHUSHAN DR. M. B. ATHREYA

HUMAN
FLOURISHING

ŚREYAS

THE HIGHEST GOOD

Dharmo viśvasya jagataḥ pratiṣṭhā

DHARMA IS THE FOUNDATION OF THE ENTIRE UNIVERSE.

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This is a working paper. Comments and suggestions are welcome and may be addressed to:

natyasastra.gurukulam@gmail.com

¹ The Padma Bhushan is one of India's most exalted civilian honours, conferred by the Government of India in recognition of distinguished service of a high order.

Abstract

Contemporary research on human flourishing has significantly broadened our understanding of well-being by moving beyond economic indicators toward multidimensional conceptions of flourishing. Yet these frameworks primarily describe and measure flourishing rather than explain the generative processes through which it arises and is sustained, or the direction in which human formation is rightly ordered. This paper develops *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*, presenting a comprehensive civilisational framework grounded in four interconnected principles: *Dharma* as the normative principle of order, the *Triguṇas* as the psychology of consciousness cultivation, the *Puruṣārthas* as the integrated architecture of human ends, and *Bhakti*, animated through the aesthetic pedagogy of *Rasa*, as the relational and integrative principle that transforms duty into joyful participation. Drawing upon historical exemplars as civilisational case studies and engaging contemporary theories of human development and flourishing, the paper distinguishes human formation from flourishing while examining the processes through which ethical, psychological, relational, institutional, and civilisational orders become aligned. It argues that flourishing is not merely a state to be measured, nor development merely a process of change, but an emergent order of human life whose *Dhārmic* direction matters. The paper advances *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing* as a complementary explanatory framework for understanding how flourishing is generated, cultivated, sustained, and transmitted across generations, while identifying pathways for its empirical examination through longitudinal study of formative practices and their effects on human organisation and participation.



Part I: Human Flourishing as a Global Conversation

1. Introduction

The pursuit of human flourishing has emerged as one of the defining interdisciplinary conversations of the twenty-first century. Across economics, psychology, philosophy, public health, education, and public policy, scholars increasingly recognise that conventional measures of societal progress, centred primarily on economic output and material prosperity, are inadequate indicators of the quality of human life.² Although national income and productivity remain important, they cannot by themselves account for whether individuals and communities genuinely flourish.

This recognition has stimulated successive generations of research seeking more comprehensive conceptions of well-being. Early efforts expanded beyond economic indicators through measures such as the Physical Quality of Life Index (PQLI) and later the Human Development Index (HDI), emphasising health, education, and longevity as essential dimensions of development.³ Subsequent initiatives, including the WHO Quality of Life (WHOQOL) framework, the OECD Better Life Index, the Social Progress Index, and the World Happiness Report, further broadened the conversation by incorporating social

² Simon Kuznets, *National Income, 1929–1932* (New York: National Bureau of Economic Research, 1934), 7–9, 85–87; Amartya Sen, *Development as Freedom* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1999), 13–34.

³ David M. Morris, *Measuring the Condition of the World's Poor: The Physical Quality of Life Index* (New York: Pergamon Press, 1979), 3–20; United Nations Development Programme, *Human Development Report 2025* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2025), 1–26.



relationships, environmental quality, civic participation, subjective well-being, and institutional trust.⁴

Parallel developments within psychology have similarly shifted attention from pathology toward human strengths and optimal functioning. Positive Psychology, particularly through the work of Martin E. P. Seligman, Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi, Christopher Peterson, and others, has highlighted the importance of meaning, character, engagement, relationships, and purpose as essential components of a flourishing life.⁵ More recently, the interdisciplinary work of Professor Tyler J. VanderWeele and the Harvard *Human Flourishing Program* has provided one of the most comprehensive contemporary frameworks for understanding flourishing through domains such as happiness and life satisfaction, physical and mental health, meaning and purpose, character and virtue, close social relationships, and financial/material stability. Together, these developments represent a significant broadening of scholarly understanding, moving beyond wealth as the principal measure of progress toward richer and more holistic conceptions of human well-being.⁶

Yet an important philosophical question remains. While contemporary scholarship has made remarkable progress in identifying the dimensions and indicators of flourishing, comparatively less attention has been devoted to the generative principles from which flourishing arises. Existing frameworks describe what flourishing looks like and increasingly provide sophisticated methods for measuring it, but they leave open a deeper question: What forms the kind of human being, the kind of society, and ultimately the kind of civilisation from which authentic and enduring flourishing naturally emerges?

⁴ World Health Organization, *WHOQOL: Measuring Quality of Life* (Geneva: World Health Organization, 1997), 1–14; Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, *How's Life? 2024: Measuring Well-Being* (Paris: OECD Publishing, 2024), 19–39; Michael Green et al., *Social Progress Index 2025: Methodology Summary* (Washington, DC: Social Progress Imperative, 2025); *World Happiness Report 2025* (New York: Sustainable Development Solutions Network, 2025), Introduction.

⁵ Martin E. P. Seligman, *Flourish* (New York: Free Press, 2011), 1–24; Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi, *Flow: The Psychology of Optimal Experience* (New York: Harper & Row, 1990), 3–26; Christopher Peterson and Martin E. P. Seligman, *Character Strengths and Virtues: A Handbook and Classification* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2004), 3–31.

⁶ Tyler J. VanderWeele, *Human Flourishing: An Introductory Framework* (Cambridge, MA: Human Flourishing Program, Harvard Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Harvard University, n.d.), 3–6.

It is precisely this question that the *Dhārmic* tradition seeks to address. Rather than beginning with external indicators or measurable outcomes, it begins with the cultivation of the human person. The *Dhārmic* tradition offers not merely an ethical system or religious worldview, but a civilisational theory of flourishing. Drawing upon foundational sources such as the concept of *Ṛta* in the *Ṛgveda*, the *Upaniṣads*, the *Bhagavad Gītā*, the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, and the philosophical synthesis of Ādi Śaṅkarācārya⁷, it understands flourishing as the emergent consequence of living in harmony with *Dharma*, the principle of moral, psychological, social, and cosmic order that sustains both individual and collective life.⁸ Within this civilisational framework, flourishing is understood through the integrated relationship between *Dharma*, the *Puruṣārthas*, the cultivation of consciousness through the doctrine of the *Triguṇas*, and the transformative, relational power of *Bhakti*. These foundational themes will be developed in the chapters that follow.

The *Dhārmic* tradition therefore approaches flourishing from a complementary perspective. It asks not merely what constitutes flourishing, but how it is generated. It understands flourishing as emerging through the harmonious ordering of consciousness, conduct, relationships, institutions, and civilisation itself. Individual flourishing and societal flourishing are therefore viewed as mutually constitutive, each sustained by the orienting principle of *Dharma*.

This paper develops *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing* by bringing these foundational insights into conversation with contemporary interdisciplinary scholarship. It first examines *Dharma* as the foundational principle of flourishing before exploring the cultivation of consciousness through the *Dhārmic* psychology of human flourishing. It then considers the *Puruṣārthas*, *Bhakti*, and the aesthetic pedagogy of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* as the ethical, psychological, aesthetic, and social architecture of flourishing. Finally, it examines the lives and teachings of representative exemplars, including Śrī Rāma, Sant Ravidas, Kabir, the *Gopīs*, Mīrābāī, Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu, Nārāyaṇa Guru, and related

⁷ Ādi Śaṅkarācārya (Ādi meaning ‘the original’ or ‘the first’; traditionally dated to the eighth century CE) was the pre-eminent exponent of *Vedānta*. His commentaries on the *Upaniṣads*, the *Bhagavad Gītā*, and the *Brahma Sūtra* profoundly shaped the subsequent development of Indian philosophy.

⁸ *Ṛgveda* 10.190.1–3; *Īśāvāsya Upaniṣad* 1–2; *Bhagavad Gītā* 3.19, 14.5–18, 18.66; *Nāṭyaśāstra* 1.107–108; Ādi Śaṅkarācārya, *Bhagavad Gītā Bhāṣya*, commentaries on 3.19 and 18.66.

comparative figures, not as isolated religious or historical traditions, but as complementary embodiments of a coherent civilisational vision of flourishing.

The central thesis of this paper is that human flourishing is not merely an outcome to be measured, but a civilisational process of human formation to be cultivated. Put differently, human flourishing is not simply a condition to be observed; it emerges through the progressive cultivation of right order within persons, relationships, institutions, and civilisation. The chapters that follow develop this proposition by examining how *Dharma*, the cultivation of consciousness through the *Triguṇas*, the integrated architecture of the *Puruṣārthas*, and the relational power of *Bhakti* together generate the conditions under which individuals, communities, institutions, and civilisations flourish.

The originality of this paper lies not merely in recovering these classical ideas, but in synthesising them into a coherent explanatory framework for understanding how human flourishing is generated.

1.1. Contributions of this Paper

This paper makes three principal theoretical contributions to the contemporary study of human flourishing.

First, it shifts the analytical focus from describing and measuring flourishing to explaining the generative processes through which flourishing emerges. Rather than treating flourishing primarily as an outcome, it distinguishes the processes of human formation from the condition of flourishing itself, and argues that flourishing emerges through the progressive cultivation and alignment of ethical, psychological, relational, institutional, and civilisational orders. Human formation is therefore not understood merely as change or development, but as formation whose *Dhārmic* direction matters.

Secondly, it synthesises the four foundational concepts of the *Dhārmic* tradition: *Dharma*, the *Triguṇas*, the *Puruṣārthas*, and *Bhakti*, into a unified explanatory framework. While each has received substantial independent scholarly attention, this paper argues that their significance lies in their dynamic interaction rather than in their isolated interpretation.

Together, they provide an account of how consciousness is cultivated, human ends are ordered, relationships are integrated, and conduct is oriented toward *Dharma*.

Thirdly, the paper extends contemporary flourishing research beyond the individual by locating flourishing within a broader civilisational ecology. It argues that families, communities, educational institutions, artistic traditions, and systems of governance are not merely contexts within which flourishing occurs, but are themselves constitutive dimensions of a flourishing civilisation. They are principal means through which human formation and flourishing are generated, sustained, and transmitted across generations.

Taken together, these contributions advance *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing* as a complementary explanatory framework that accounts for the ethical, psychological, relational, institutional, and civilisational processes through which flourishing is cultivated, while also identifying the formative practices through which these processes may be subjected to empirical examination over time.

The argument proceeds in four movements. It first establishes the philosophical foundations of flourishing, then examines the mechanisms through which flourishing is cultivated, next considers historical embodiments of these principles, and finally synthesises them into *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*.

In doing so, the paper contributes a distinctive civilisational perspective to the contemporary global conversation on human flourishing.

Part II: Philosophical Foundations & Psychology

2. Dharma: The Anchor of Human Flourishing

The preceding Chapter argued that contemporary scholarship has significantly advanced our understanding of the dimensions and indicators of human flourishing. Yet a deeper philosophical question remains unanswered: What generates flourishing? The *Dhārmic*

tradition approaches this question by identifying a foundational principle that precedes external well-being, institutional design, and even psychological states. That principle is *Dharma*, the normative anchor of *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing* developed in this paper.

Throughout this paper, *Dharma* should not be understood in isolation from the remaining components of the framework. Rather, *Dharma* provides the normative orientation that animates every subsequent component of the framework. It is progressively embodied through the cultivation of consciousness (Chapter 3), the integrated ordering of human ends (Chapter 4), and the relational transformation effected through *Bhakti* (Chapter 5).

Dharma has often been translated as religion, duty, law, righteousness, morality, or virtue. None of these renderings, however, adequately captures its philosophical scope. *Dharma* is not merely a code of conduct, nor simply a body of religious obligations. It is the principle of right order that sustains the individual, society, nature, and the cosmos. *Dharma* resists reduction to any single Western conceptual category precisely because it integrates ontology, ethics, law, and social order into a unified vision of reality.⁹ *Dharma* is therefore best understood not as one virtue among many, but as the principle that renders the virtues themselves coherent.

This Chapter argues that *Dharma* is the generative principle of human flourishing. Human flourishing emerges not primarily from wealth, institutional efficiency, or subjective well-being, but from progressively aligning individual character and collective life with *Dharma*.

The discussion proceeds by gradually expanding the scope of *Dharma*, from the moral life of the individual to the cultivation of consciousness, the ordering of institutions, the continuity of civilisation, and finally the cosmic order from which *Dharma* itself derives. This progression establishes the normative foundation upon which the remainder of the paper is constructed.

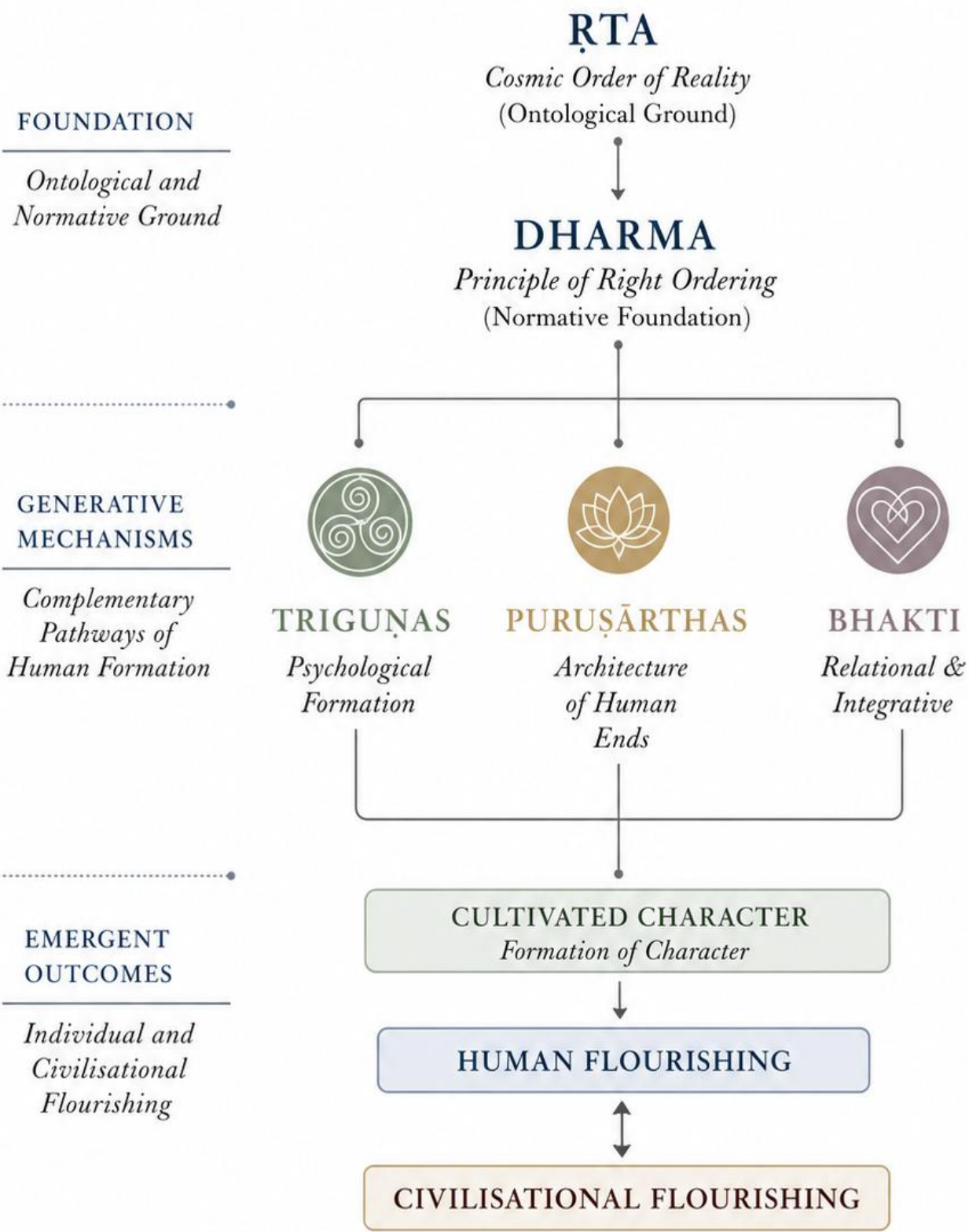
To establish this claim, the discussion traces the philosophical evolution of *Dharma* from

⁹ Wilhelm Halbfass, *India and Europe: An Essay in Understanding* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1988), 309–334.

the Vedic conception of *Rta*, before examining its moral, psychological, social, civilisational, and cosmic dimensions.

Figure 1 summarises the generative architecture developed throughout the remainder of the paper. It illustrates how *Dharma* functions as the normative anchor linking consciousness, ethical life, relational integration, and ultimately both human and civilisational flourishing.

Figure 1. The Generative Architecture of Human Flourishing in the Dhārmic Tradition



Note. *Ṛta* provides the ontological ground of reality, while *Dharma* establishes the normative principle of right ordering. The *Triguṇas*, the *Puruṣārthas*, and *Bhakti* constitute complementary generative mechanisms through which cultivated character emerges. Human flourishing arises from the dynamic interaction of these dimensions and, in turn, contributes to the flourishing and renewal of civilisation.

2.1. From Ṛta to Dharma: The Evolution of Order

The earliest expression of order within the Vedic tradition is the concept of *Ṛta*. The *Rgveda* proclaims: ऋतं च सत्यं चाभीद्धात् तपसोऽध्यजायत। (*From the power of creative tapas arose Ṛta and Satya*¹⁰).

Although this celebrated passage appears in a cosmogonic context, two terms merit brief clarification. *Tapas* denotes the creative and generative potency through which order comes into being, while *Satya* signifies truth as correspondence with reality and participation in that order. Together they express the Vedic intuition that the universe is grounded in both creative power and intelligible truth. The verse therefore conveys a profound philosophical insight: reality itself possesses an intrinsic order.

Over time, the concept of *Dharma* emerged as the human participation in this cosmic order. If *Ṛta* describes how reality is constituted, *Dharma* prescribes how human beings ought to live within that reality. The evolution from *Ṛta* to *Dharma* represents one of the defining developments of Indian intellectual history, expanding the idea of order from cosmology into ethics, jurisprudence, and social life.¹¹

From the perspective of human flourishing, this development is decisive. Human flourishing is therefore generated by participation in an order that precedes human choice rather than by the mere satisfaction of human preference.

2.3 Dharma as Moral Order

The *Mahābhārata* succinctly expresses the reciprocal relationship between *Dharma* and human well-being: धर्मो रक्षति रक्षितः। (*Dharma protects those who protect it*¹²).

This maxim does not imply supernatural reward for moral behaviour. Rather, it recognises

¹⁰ *Rgveda* 10.190.1–3.

¹¹ P. V. Kane, *History of Dharmaśāstra*, 5 vols. (Poona: Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute, 1930–1962), 1:3–18, 91–123; 2, pt. 1:1–62.

¹² *Mahābhārata*, Vana Parva 313.128.

that moral order possesses a self-sustaining character. Individuals and societies flourish when they uphold the principles that preserve justice, truthfulness, compassion, and responsibility.

The *Bhagavad Gītā* similarly presents *Dharma* as the foundation of ethical action. Arjuna's crisis is not simply psychological but moral. Kṛṣṇa calls him to act according to *Dharma* rather than attachment or aversion, thereby locating flourishing in disciplined participation in moral order rather than in the pursuit of immediate happiness.¹³

Classical Indian ethics is best understood not as rule-based morality but as an integrated vision in which virtue, practical wisdom, and social responsibility mutually reinforce one another. In this respect, *Dharma* resembles neither deontological obligation nor utilitarian calculation. Rather, it constitutes an ethics of right ordering in which character, action, and consequence remain internally related. Such an understanding aligns closely with contemporary virtue ethics while extending it through the broader metaphysical horizon of *Dharma*.¹⁴

2.2. Dharma as Psychological Order

The *Dhārmic* tradition recognises that ethical conduct cannot be sustained without the cultivation of consciousness. Accordingly, *Dharma* is as much an inward discipline as an outward obligation.

Ādi Śaṅkarācārya repeatedly emphasises the necessity of *viveka* (discrimination), *vairāgya* (dispassion), and mastery over the mind as prerequisites for higher knowledge. In the *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi*, he writes: चित्तस्य शुद्धये कर्म न तु वस्तूपलब्धये। (*Action is for the purification of the mind, not for the direct realisation of Reality*¹⁵).

This insight carries profound implications for human flourishing. Ethical conduct is not merely socially beneficial; it transforms consciousness, rendering the individual capable of

¹³ *Bhagavad Gītā* 2.31–38; 3.19

¹⁴ Bimal Krishna Matilal, *The Moral Dilemma: Essays on Indian Ethics* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2002), 1–28.

¹⁵ Ādi Śaṅkarācārya, *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi*, verse 11.

wisdom, freedom, and enduring well-being.

The *Bhagavad Gītā* complements this psychological vision by describing the disciplined mind as one's greatest ally and the undisciplined mind as one's greatest adversary.¹⁶ *Dharma* therefore entails the progressive ordering of consciousness, a theme that reaches fuller expression in the *Dhārmic* psychology of human flourishing explored in the next Chapter. Psychological flourishing is thus understood not merely as emotional well-being but as the progressive ordering of consciousness in accordance with *Dharma*.

2.3. Dharma as Institutional and Social Order

Human flourishing unfolds within relationships and institutions. Consequently, *Dharma* extends beyond personal virtue to encompass the ethical ordering of family, education, governance, economic life, and political authority.

The *Mahābhārata* consistently portrays rulers as custodians of *Dharma* rather than proprietors of power. Political legitimacy derives not from coercive capacity but from fidelity to justice and the welfare of the people.¹⁷

Dharma functions simultaneously as a personal ethic and as the organising principle of social order, integrating law, ritual, governance, and communal life into a coherent civilisational framework. Institutions flourish, therefore, not merely through efficiency or regulation but through sustained fidelity to the purposes for which they exist. Institutions therefore do not merely administer flourishing; they cultivate the conditions under which flourishing becomes possible.¹⁸

2.4. Dharma as Civilisational Order

Institutions do not exist in isolation. They are sustained by wider traditions of meaning, memory, education, artistic expression, and shared moral imagination through which societies preserve and renew themselves across generations. It is at this broader level that

¹⁶ *Bhagavad Gītā* 6.5–6.

¹⁷ *Mahābhārata*, Śānti Parva 109.10–11; 259.5–11.

¹⁸ Gavin Flood, *An Introduction to Hinduism* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), 52–67, 211–236.

Dharma assumes its civilisational character.

The significance of *Dharma* extends beyond ethics and politics to civilisation itself. Civilisations endure because they preserve moral imagination, cultural memory, philosophical inquiry, artistic expression, and institutions capable of transmitting them across generations.

The *Nāṭyaśāstra* explicitly presents drama as a vehicle for preserving *Dharma*: धर्म्यम् यशस्यम् आयुष्यम् हितं बुद्धिविवर्धनम्...¹⁹ (*Nāṭya* will foster *Dharma*, fame, longevity, welfare, and the growth of intellect....).

Nāṭya educates through aesthetic experience. It refines moral perception, cultivates empathy, and transmits civilisational values without reducing them to abstract instruction.²⁰

This understanding suggests that flourishing depends not only upon virtuous individuals but also upon cultural institutions capable of shaping ethical imagination. The arts therefore occupy a central, rather than peripheral, place within *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*. Within this framework, *Nāṭya* is not entertainment but civilisational pedagogy, cultivating the ethical imagination through aesthetic experience.

2.5. Dharma as Cosmic Order

The foregoing discussion has shown that *Dharma* progressively unfolds from the moral life of the individual to the institutions and civilisation through which that life is sustained. Its deepest significance, however, becomes fully apparent only when it is viewed in relation to the cosmic order from which it originally emerged. The movement from *Rta* to *Dharma* therefore culminates by returning to its cosmological foundation.

The *Īśāvāsya Upaniṣad* begins: ईशावास्यमिदं सर्वं यत्किञ्च जगत्यां जगत्। (*All this, whatever*

¹⁹ *Nāṭyaśāstra* 1.107–108.

²⁰ Kapila Vatsyayan, *Classical Indian Dance in Literature and the Arts* (New Delhi: Sangeet Natak Akademi, 1968), 15–41.

*exists within this changing universe, is pervaded by the Divine Reality*²¹).

Reality is not fragmented but pervaded by an underlying unity. The flourishing of the individual therefore cannot ultimately be separated from the flourishing of the larger order of which the individual forms a part. Human flourishing therefore cannot be isolated from ecological balance, social justice, ethical integrity, or spiritual development. Each expresses participation in a single order.

Dharma ultimately signifies the progressive alignment of the human person with this order: from consciousness to society, from society to civilisation, and from civilisation to the cosmos itself.

2.6. Synthesising the Dhārmic Foundations of Human Flourishing

The foregoing discussion demonstrates that *Dharma* cannot adequately be understood as religion, morality, law, or social custom alone. It is the organising principle through which moral character, psychological integration, institutional legitimacy, civilisational continuity, and cosmic participation become mutually reinforcing dimensions of human flourishing.

Contemporary flourishing scholarship has significantly enriched our understanding of the outcomes and dimensions of flourishing. The *Dhārmic* tradition complements this scholarship by addressing a prior question: What generates flourishing? It argues that flourishing emerges through the progressive alignment of individuals, relationships, institutions, and civilisation with *Dharma*.

2.7. Contribution to The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing

This Chapter has established *Dharma* as the normative anchor of *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*, demonstrating that flourishing arises through alignment with the principle of right order.

²¹ Īśāvāsya Upaniṣad 1–2.

3. Human Nature and the Cultivation of Consciousness

The preceding Chapter argued that *Dharma* constitutes the organising principle of human flourishing. Yet an equally important question remains: why do human beings so often fail to live in accordance with *Dharma*? The *Dhārmic* tradition locates the answer not primarily in external institutions or social conditions, but within the structure of human consciousness itself. Ethical order cannot be sustained without psychological order. If *Dharma* provides the normative orientation of human flourishing, the *Triguṇas* explain how human beings gradually become capable of embodying that order.

The *Bhagavad Gītā* addresses this question through the *Dhārmic* psychology of human flourishing: *Sattva*, *Rajas*, and *Tamas*, the three fundamental qualities of *Prakṛti* (the dynamic matrix of nature, mind, and matter) that shape human perception, motivation, action, and character. These are not fixed personality types but dynamic tendencies whose relative predominance varies within every individual. Human flourishing therefore depends not merely upon understanding *Dharma* intellectually but upon cultivating those dispositions that render *Dhārmic* living possible.

This Chapter argues that the psychology of flourishing within the *Dhārmic* tradition consists in cultivating *Sattva*, sublimating *Rajas* into disciplined action (*Śānta Rajas*), and progressively reducing *Tamas*. Through this inner transformation, the individual becomes capable of perceiving *Dharma* clearly, acting upon it effectively, and sustaining a flourishing life.

3.1. The Triguṇas: The Dynamics of Human Qualities

The *Bhagavad Gītā* introduces the doctrine of the *Triguṇas* with remarkable psychological precision: सत्त्वं रजस्तम इति गुणाःप्रकृतिसंभवाः । निबध्नन्ति महाबाहो देहे देहिनमव्ययम्॥ (*Sattva*, *Rajas*, and *Tamas*, born of *Prakṛti*, bind the imperishable embodied Self through the

*conditions of embodied existence*²²).

The *Guṇas* therefore describe not the nature of the Self (*Ātman*), which remains immutable, but the conditions through which embodied consciousness perceives, interprets, and engages the world.²³

Classical *Sāṃkhya* philosophy distinguishes between *Puruṣa* (the witnessing Self or pure consciousness) and *Prakṛti* (the dynamic matrix of nature, mind, and matter).²⁴ The three *Guṇas* belong to this dynamic order rather than to *Puruṣa*. They therefore describe the changing conditions of embodied existence rather than the intrinsic nature of the Self.

The *Guṇas* are not moral absolutes but dynamic modes of *Prakṛti* that shape perception, motivation, action, and character. Every thought, emotion, action, institution, and culture reflects differing configurations of these three qualities. Human beings therefore cannot be understood simply in terms of fixed traits or external behaviour; they are continuously shaped by the interplay of *Sattva*, *Rajas*, and *Tamas*.

This dynamic understanding distinguishes the *Bhagavad Gītā* from many modern theories of personality. Rather than treating human nature as relatively static, the *Gītā* presents consciousness as fundamentally capable of transformation. Human flourishing is therefore neither predetermined nor accidental; it emerges through disciplined self-cultivation.

Śaṅkarācārya accordingly interprets the *Guṇas* as the conditioning forces of embodied existence. The aspirant's task is not merely to understand them intellectually but to transcend their binding influence through disciplined living and Self-knowledge. Yet such transcendence begins with learning to recognise, rightly order, and ultimately transcend the influence of the *Guṇas*. The psychology of human flourishing therefore begins not with their elimination but with their progressive right ordering.²⁵

The foregoing discussion establishes the psychological architecture upon which the

²² *Bhagavad Gītā* 14.5.

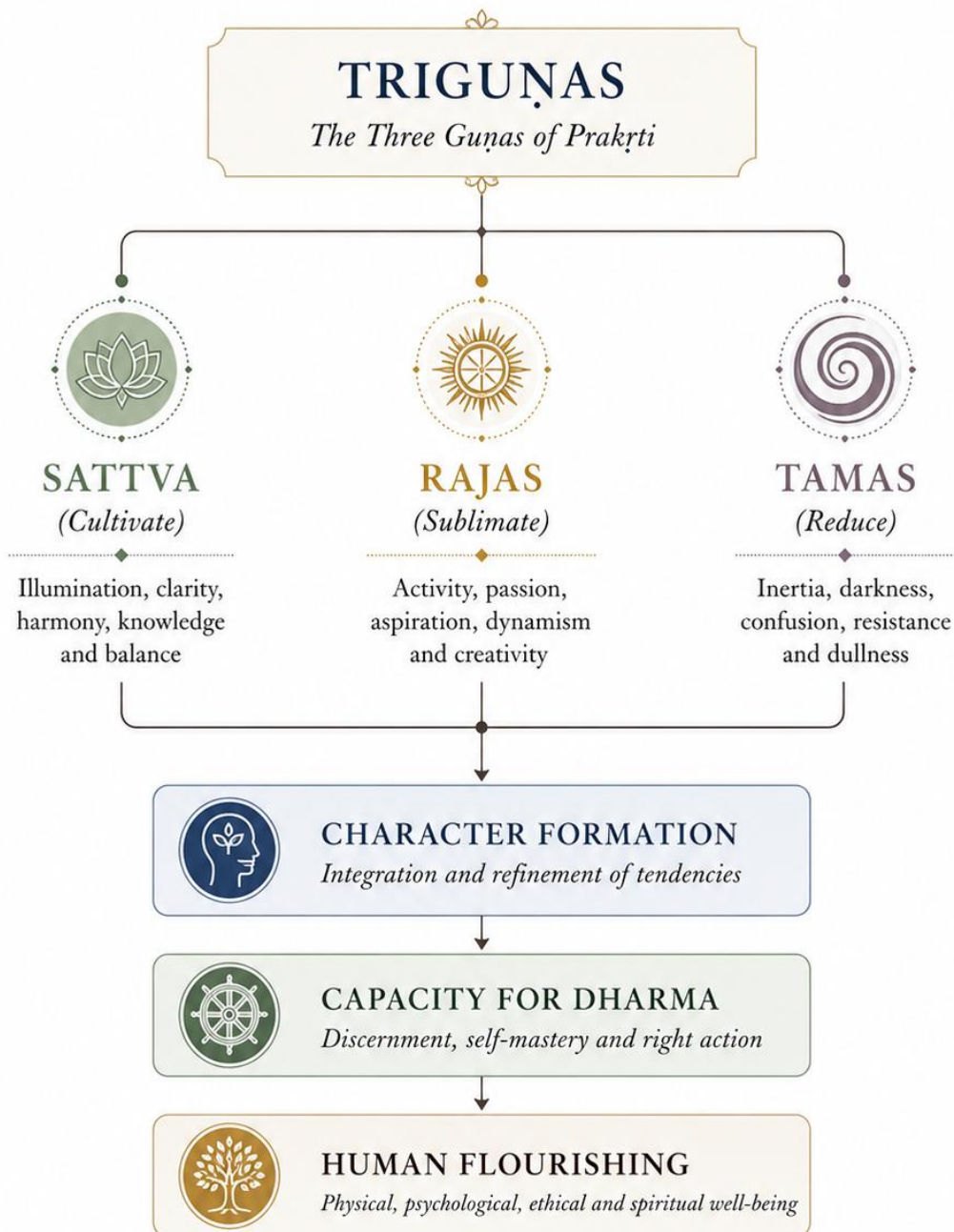
²³ Ādi Śaṅkarācārya, *Bhagavad Gītā Bhāṣya*, commentary on 14.5–8.

²⁴ Surendranath Dasgupta, *A History of Indian Philosophy*, vol. 1 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1922), 245–302; Gerald James Larson, *Classical Sāṃkhya* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1979), 169–205.

²⁵ *Ibid.*

remainder of this Chapter is built. Figure 2 summarises this *Dhārmic* psychology of human flourishing, illustrating how the progressive cultivation of *Sattva*, the sublimation of *Rajas*, and the reduction of *Tamas* together refine character, strengthen the capacity for *Dharma*, and generate the conditions under which human flourishing emerges.

Figure 2: The Cultivation of Consciousness in The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing.



Note: The *Triguṇas* shape human consciousness and conduct. Cultivating *Sattva*, sublimating *Rajas*, and reducing *Tamas* refines character, strengthens the capacity for *Dharma*, and leads to human flourishing.

The figure should not be interpreted as suggesting that the three *Guṇas* operate independently or sequentially. Rather, they interact continuously within every individual, with the cultivation of *Sattva* progressively illuminating and directing *Rajas* while diminishing the obscuring influence of *Tamas*. The chapters that follow examine each *Guṇa* individually for analytical clarity, before returning to their dynamic interaction as an integrated psychology of human flourishing.

FIGURE 2A. ILLUSTRATIVE EXEMPLARS OF THE TRIGUṆAS FROM THE RĀMĀYAṆA

ŚRĪ RĀMA	RĀVAṆA	KUMBHAKARṆA
		
SATTVA	RAJAS DOMINATED BY EGO	TAMAS
- Clarity and wisdom - Compassion and empathy - Self-mastery and equanimity - Unwavering adherence to Dharma <i>Luminosity, harmony, and ethical order</i>	- Extraordinary energy and capability - Directed by pride and self-importance - Attachment, ambition, and domination - Power without Dharma becomes adharmā <i>Restless activity divorced from higher order</i>	- Inertia and lethargy - Delusion and ignorance - Heedlessness and negligence - Resistance to learning and growth <i>Obscurity, stagnation, and decline</i>

These figures are presented as pedagogical illustrations rather than rigid psychological classifications. The three Guṇas coexist in every individual; the examples highlight their dominant orientations for explanatory purposes.

3.2. Sattva: The Foundation of Human Flourishing

Among the three *Guṇas*, *Sattva* occupies a privileged position because it illuminates reality without distortion.

The *Bhagavad Gītā* describes *Sattva* thus: तत्र सत्त्वं निर्मलत्वात् प्रकाशकमनामयम्। सुखसङ्गेन

बध्नाति ज्ञानसङ्गेन चानघ॥ (*Sattva, being pure, is luminous and free from disease; it binds through attachment to happiness and knowledge*²⁶).

Sattva is characterised by clarity, balance, truthfulness, compassion, discernment, serenity, and self-mastery. It does not merely produce pleasant emotions but enables accurate perception of reality. Consequently, *Sattva* provides the psychological foundation for ethical judgment (*Viveka*) and responsible action. It is therefore the psychological condition under which *Dharma* becomes both intelligible and practicable.²⁷

From the perspective of human flourishing, *Sattva* performs a crucial function. *Dharma* cannot be embodied unless it is first perceived. A mind clouded by agitation or inertia cannot reliably distinguish right from wrong, enduring good from transient pleasure, or wisdom from impulse. *Sattva* therefore renders human flourishing possible by illuminating both reality and one's responsibilities within it.

Śaṅkarācārya repeatedly identifies purity of mind (*citta-śuddhi*) as the indispensable preparation for higher knowledge. In his commentary on the *Bhagavad Gītā*, he argues that selfless action performed according to *Dharma* gradually purifies the mind, making it fit for liberating knowledge. Human flourishing thus begins not with external achievement but with inward clarity.²⁸

3.3. Rajas: Energy to be Sublimated

If *Sattva* provides clarity, *Rajas* supplies energy.

The *Bhagavad Gītā* describes *Rajas* as arising from desire and attachment, generating restless activity and constant striving. Left unchecked, *Rajas* manifests as ambition, anxiety, competition, possessiveness, and insatiable craving. Such activity often produces material success while simultaneously undermining inner peace.²⁹

²⁶ *Bhagavad Gītā* 14.6.

²⁷ *Bhagavad Gītā* 14.6; Ādi Śaṅkarācārya, *Bhagavad Gītā Bhāṣya*, commentary on 14.6.

²⁸ Ādi Śaṅkarācārya, *Bhagavad Gītā Bhāṣya*, commentary on 3.19.

²⁹ *Bhagavad Gītā* 14.7.

Yet the *Dhārmic* tradition does not advocate the suppression of *Rajas*. Human civilisation, creativity, governance, scholarship, commerce, and artistic achievement all require vigorous action. The challenge is therefore not to eliminate *Rajas* but to transform it.

This paper adopts Dr. M. B. Athreya's formulation of *Śānta Rajas*³⁰, tranquil dynamism, to describe this transformation. *Rajas* governed by ego becomes restless activism; *Rajas* governed by *Dharma* becomes disciplined service. It is the difference between ambition driven by attachment and purposeful action performed in the spirit of *Karma Yoga*. *Śānta Rajas* therefore denotes disciplined energy directed toward service rather than self-aggrandisement.

The *Bhagavad Gītā* repeatedly calls for precisely such disciplined action: तस्मादसक्तः सततं कार्यं कर्म समाचर। (Therefore, always perform the work that ought to be done, without attachment to rewards, while remaining fully committed to achieving the rightful purpose of the action³¹).

Human flourishing does not require withdrawal from the world but participation in it with clarity, self-restraint, and freedom from possessiveness. *Rajas* thus becomes not an obstacle to flourishing but its dynamic instrument when illumined by *Sattva* and guided by *Dharma*.

3.4. Tamas: The Obstacle to Flourishing

The third *Guṇa*, *Tamas*, represents inertia, ignorance, confusion, and resistance to growth.

The *Bhagavad Gītā* states: तमस्त्वज्ञानजं विद्धि मोहनं सर्वदेहिनाम्। (Know *Tamas* to arise from ignorance; it deludes all embodied beings³²).

³⁰ The expression *Śānta Rajas* (tranquil dynamism) is adopted from the leadership and management writings of Padma Bhushan Dr. M. B. Athreya, who employs it to describe disciplined, purpose-oriented action governed by ethical restraint rather than ego-driven ambition.

³¹ *Bhagavad Gītā* 3.19.

³² *Bhagavad Gītā* 14.8.

Unlike *Sattva*, which illuminates, and *Rajas*, which energises, *Tamas* obscures reality and diminishes human potential. It manifests as apathy, indifference, habitual error, violence, addiction, fear, and the unwillingness to undertake necessary effort.

The *Dhārmic* tradition therefore regards *Tamas* not as moral depravity but as a condition requiring transformation. Education, disciplined practice, self-reflection, aesthetic cultivation, and spiritual discipline all seek to reduce *Tāmasic* tendencies by awakening awareness and purposeful action. The reduction of *Tamas* therefore represents not merely the removal of ignorance but the recovery of the human capacity for growth, responsibility, and transformation.

In contemporary psychological language, *Tamas* may be compared, though never reduced, to states of chronic passivity, learned helplessness, or cognitive rigidity. The *Gītā*, however, situates these within a broader metaphysical understanding of consciousness, emphasising that human beings retain the capacity for transformation through sustained practice.³³

This movement from ignorance to illumination finds eloquent expression in the celebrated prayer of the *Bṛhadāranyaka Upaniṣad*: तमसो मा ज्योतिर्गमय, (*Lead me from darkness to light*). The prayer encapsulates the psychological movement described throughout this Chapter: from the obscuring influence of *Tamas* towards the clarity of *Sattva*, through which the individual becomes increasingly capable of perceiving and embodying *Dharma*.³⁴

3.5. Cultivating Consciousness

The *Dhārmic* psychology of human flourishing is ultimately practical rather than descriptive. It seeks not merely to explain human behaviour but to transform it.

The *Bhagavad Gītā* identifies multiple disciplines that cultivate *Sattva* and gradually transform *Rajas* and *Tamas*: disciplined action (*Karma Yoga*), self-study (*svādhyāya*), meditation (*dhyāna*), moderation in food and lifestyle, devotion (*Bhakti*), sacrifice (*yajña*), charity (*dāna*), and disciplined speech. These practices reshape consciousness by aligning

³³ Gerald James Larson, *Classical Sāṃkhya* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1979), 169–205.

³⁴ *Bṛhadāranyaka Upaniṣad* 1.3.28.

daily life with *Dharma*³⁵. The cultivation of consciousness is thus understood as a lifelong process of character formation rather than a temporary programme of behavioural modification.

Equally important are the formative influences of education, community (*satsaṅga*), artistic experience, and cultural participation. Within this wider psychology of human flourishing, the *Nāṭyaśāstra* acquires renewed significance as a pedagogy of emotional refinement and ethical cultivation. Through aesthetic experience, individuals refine emotional intelligence, moral imagination, and empathy, qualities indispensable for the growth of *Sattva*.³⁶

The cultivation of consciousness is therefore not confined to ascetic practice but encompasses every dimension of human life. Education, culture, work, family, governance, and spiritual discipline all become means of shaping character.

3.6. Towards a Psychology of Human Flourishing

The doctrine of the *Triguṇas* offers a distinctive psychology of human flourishing.

Contemporary psychology often investigates flourishing through cognition, emotion, resilience, personality, or subjective well-being. The *Bhagavad Gītā* complements these perspectives by directing attention to the underlying quality of consciousness from which thoughts, emotions, and actions arise. Human flourishing is neither an accidental psychological state nor merely an adaptive response to favourable circumstances; it is the gradual refinement of consciousness. A similar dialogue between classical Indian thought and modern psychology is developed by Swami Akhilananda, who presents classical Indian psychology as a systematic account of the cultivation and transformation of consciousness rather than merely a description of mental states.³⁷

Within this framework, *Sattva* illumines the perception of *Dharma*; *Śānta Rajas* enables disciplined participation in it; and the progressive reduction of *Tamas* removes the

³⁵ *Bhagavad Gītā* 17.7–22; 18.23–66.

³⁶ *Nāṭyaśāstra* 1.107–108; Kapila Vatsyayan, *Classical Indian Dance in Literature and the Arts* (New Delhi: Sangeet Natak Akademi, 1968).

³⁷ Swami Akhilananda, *Hindu Psychology: Its Meaning for the West* (London: George Allen & Unwin, 1946).

obscurations that hinder its clear perception and embodiment..

Flourishing therefore arises not through the suppression of action but through the harmonious ordering of consciousness, cultivated progressively until ethical understanding becomes embodied in thought, action, and character. The *Triguṇas* therefore constitute the psychological bridge between the principle of *Dharma* established in the previous Chapter and the ethical architecture of the *Puruṣārthas* examined in the next. If *Dharma* identifies the principle of right order, the *Triguṇas* explain the psychological process through which human beings become inwardly capable of embodying that order in thought, action, and character.

3.7. Psychological Contribution to The Dhārmic Theory

This Chapter has examined the psychological mechanism through which human flourishing is cultivated. If *Dharma* provides the normative anchor of flourishing, the *Triguṇas* explain how consciousness is progressively refined until the individual becomes capable of embodying *Dharma* in thought, action, and character.

The following Chapter develops the ethical architecture of flourishing through the integrated framework of the *Puruṣārthas*, demonstrating how rightly ordered consciousness finds expression in a rightly ordered life.

Part III: The Architecture of Human Flourishing

4. The Puruṣārthas: The Normative Architecture

The previous Chapter argued that human flourishing depends upon the cultivation of consciousness through the refinement of the *Triguṇas*. Yet psychological formation alone does not determine how a flourishing life ought to be lived. A rightly ordered consciousness must find expression in a rightly ordered life. The *Dhārmic* tradition addresses this practical question through the *Puruṣārthas*, understood not as four independent objectives but as the normative architecture through which human flourishing is realised.

The *Puruṣārthas* are not merely four human aspirations arranged within an external hierarchy. They constitute a structure of dependence in which *Dharma* is the generative principle that orders and legitimises the pursuit of *Artha* and *Kāma*, thereby opening the horizon towards *Mokṣa* as the fullest expression of human freedom.³⁸

Modern scholarship frequently describes the *Puruṣārthas* as the ‘four aims of life’, implying a plurality of distinct goals that individuals pursue or balance according to circumstance. While pedagogically useful, such a description understates the conceptual sophistication of the classical tradition. The *Puruṣārthas* are better understood as an integrated order of human ends in which material prosperity, desire, ethical responsibility, and spiritual freedom are harmonised within a coherent vision of the good life. They constitute not a collection of competing aspirations but a unified framework through which human flourishing is cultivated and sustained.³⁹

This Chapter argues that *Dharma* functions as the governing principle of this normative architecture. It orders the acquisition and deployment of *Artha*, educates *Kāma* into life-giving desire, and culminates in *Mokṣa* as the highest expression of inner freedom. Human flourishing therefore consists not in maximising any single dimension of life but in integrating all four within an ordered moral and spiritual whole.

4.1. Dharma: The Governing Principle

Within the normative architecture of the *Puruṣārthas*, *Dharma* occupies a unique and foundational position. Although conventionally enumerated alongside *Artha*, *Kāma*, and *Mokṣa*, it is qualitatively different from them. *Dharma* is not merely one component of the framework but the governing principle that gives coherence to the whole.

This understanding is reflected in the traditional etymological phrase: धारयति इति धर्मः । (*Dharma is that which upholds, sustains, or supports*). The expression captures the distinctive role of *Dharma* within the *Puruṣārthas*. It does not merely prescribe right

³⁸ Patrick Olivelle, *The Āśrama System: The History and Hermeneutics of a Religious Institution* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993), 77–119.

³⁹ Ibid.

conduct; it is the sustaining principle that upholds the moral, social, and civilisational order within which the other human ends acquire their legitimacy and coherence

As discussed in the previous Chapter, *Dharma* itself is grounded in *Ṛta*, the ontological order that renders reality intelligible. If *Ṛta* denotes the ground of order, *Dharma* expresses that order within the sphere of human action. The *Puruṣārthas* therefore derive their coherence not from convention alone but from participation in a deeper moral and cosmic order.

Human flourishing is, accordingly, generated by progressive alignment with *Dharma*. The *Puruṣārthas* describe how this alignment becomes embodied in the practical ordering of human life through the ethical governance of wealth, the education of desire, and the pursuit of inner freedom.

The *Mahābhārata* captures the reciprocal relationship succinctly: धर्मो रक्षति रक्षितः । (*Dharma protects those who protect it*⁴⁰).

This maxim points beyond individual morality to a deeper civilisational insight: right order possesses a self-sustaining character, while disorder ultimately undermines both individuals and institutions. Similarly, the *Bhagavad Gītā* presents *Dharma* as the principle through which action, social responsibility, and spiritual aspiration acquire legitimacy and meaning.⁴¹

Power and desire do not become legitimate merely through their pursuit; they become legitimate only when grounded in *Dharma* as the principle of right ordering. *Dharma* therefore functions not merely as an external moral constraint but as an internalised principle of right ordering. It does not simply limit the pursuit of *Artha* and *Kāma*; it renders their pursuit morally intelligible by orienting them towards the common good and the cultivation of human flourishing. Ethical restraint thus arises not only through rules or social expectation but through the cultivation of dispositions aligned with *Dharma* itself.

⁴⁰ *Mahābhārata*, Vana Parva 313.128.

⁴¹ *Bhagavad Gītā* 2.31–38; 3.19; 18.66.

Within the normative architecture of human flourishing, *Dharma* performs three indispensable functions. First, it provides the ethical criteria by which wealth, desire, and power are evaluated. Secondly, it resolves conflicts between competing goods by orienting action towards the common good rather than individual preference. Finally, it integrates worldly engagement with spiritual aspiration, preventing both moral relativism and ascetic withdrawal.

Without *Dharma*, *Artha* degenerates into exploitation, *Kāma* into indulgence, and *Mokṣa* into a private quest detached from social responsibility. The integrated order collapses because its governing principle has been removed. Human flourishing therefore begins not with the pursuit of prosperity or happiness but with the cultivation of right order in thought, conduct, relationships, and institutions. It is this ordering principle that enables the *Puruṣārthas* to function as an integrated architecture of flourishing rather than as a collection of independent aims. The discussion now turns to the first of these dimensions, *Artha*, whose legitimacy and contribution to flourishing derive entirely from its ordering by *Dharma*.

4.2. Artha: Material Prosperity Ordered by Dharma

The second component of this normative architecture is *Artha*, a concept considerably broader than wealth alone. Classical Indian thought understands *Artha* as encompassing material resources, economic capability, political order, institutional stability, security, education, and the practical conditions necessary for sustaining individual and collective life.⁴²

The *Arthaśāstra* recognises the indispensable role of economic organisation and statecraft in maintaining social order, yet it consistently assumes that political and economic power exist for the preservation of *Dharma* rather than as ends in themselves.⁴³ Likewise, the *Mahābhārata* repeatedly cautions against wealth acquired without righteousness, recognising that prosperity divorced from ethical order ultimately destroys both the

⁴² Kauṭilya, *Arthaśāstra*, trans. Patrick Olivelle (New York: Oxford University Press, 2013), 1.7–1.19.

⁴³ *Ibid.*

individual and the polity.⁴⁴

The *Dhārmic* tradition therefore rejects two opposing errors. It neither glorifies poverty nor sanctifies wealth. Material prosperity is a legitimate and necessary dimension of human flourishing, but only when earned, governed, and deployed in accordance with *Dharma*.

This insight remains strikingly relevant in contemporary societies. Wealth contributes to flourishing when it strengthens families, sustains institutions, supports education, encourages artistic and cultural life, relieves suffering, and promotes the common good. Detached from *Dharma*, however, *Artha* becomes self-referential. Economic growth ceases to serve persons and instead reduces persons, communities, and institutions to instruments of accumulation.

Within the architecture of human flourishing, *Artha* is therefore not an autonomous sphere governed solely by efficiency or utility. It is a moral resource whose legitimacy depends upon its service to life rightly ordered.

Power and prosperity therefore derive their legitimacy not from their possession but from the ends they serve. Detached from *Dharma*, *Artha* becomes an instrument of accumulation and domination; governed by *Dharma*, it becomes a means of stewardship, responsible governance, social responsibility, and the common good.

4.3. Kāma: Desire Educated by Dharma

If *Artha* provides the material conditions for flourishing, *Kāma* enriches human existence through the cultivation of rightly ordered desire.

Few concepts have been more persistently misunderstood. Modern discourse frequently equates *Kāma* with sensual gratification. The classical tradition presents a much richer understanding. *Kāma* encompasses aesthetic delight, friendship, affection, beauty, artistic creativity, intellectual curiosity, familial love, and every form of desire that contributes to

⁴⁴ *Mahābhārata*, *Śānti Parva*, selected passages on *rājadharmā*.

the fullness of human life.

The *Bhagavad Gītā* provides the governing hermeneutic for understanding *Kāma*:
 धर्मविरुद्धो भूतेषु कामोऽस्मि भरतर्षभ। (*I am desire that is not opposed to Dharma, O best of the Bharatas*⁴⁵).

This declaration transforms the discussion. Desire itself is not rejected; rather, it is morally educated. The question is not whether human beings should desire, but whether desire participates in or opposes *Dharma*. The legitimacy of desire therefore depends not upon its intensity but upon its orientation. Desire becomes life-giving when it participates in *Dharma* and destructive when it seeks fulfilment independently of it. The education of desire therefore becomes one of the defining tasks of a flourishing civilisation, for desire shapes not only individual conduct but also the ethical character of families, institutions, and cultures.

The *Dhārmic* tradition therefore proposes neither indulgence nor repression but education. Desire becomes a force for flourishing when directed toward goods that deepen human dignity, strengthen relationships, cultivate beauty, and enrich the shared life of society.

This balanced understanding extends to the care of the body itself. The classical dictum
 शरीरमाद्यं खलु धर्मसाधनम् । (*The body is indeed the primary instrument for the practice of Dharma*⁴⁶), reminds us that restraint does not imply the rejection of embodied life. Rather, the body is to be cultivated, disciplined, and cared for as the indispensable medium through which *Dharma* is realised. Desire is therefore educated not by denial but by directing it towards the preservation and flourishing of life rightly ordered.

The *Nāṭyaśāstra* illustrates this principle through its theory of *rasa*. Aesthetic experience refines rather than merely gratifies emotion. Through disciplined artistic participation, individuals learn empathy, discernment, emotional balance, and delight in higher forms of beauty. *Nāṭya* becomes an educational practice that transforms *Kāma* into an instrument of

⁴⁵ *Bhagavad Gītā* 7.11.

⁴⁶ Commonly attributed to Kālidāsa, *Kumārasambhava* 5.33.

ethical and psychological maturation.⁴⁷ *Nāṭya* thus functions not merely as artistic expression but as a civilisational pedagogy through which desire is refined into aesthetic, ethical, and relational excellence.

Within the architecture of human flourishing, *Kāma* is therefore neither the enemy of *Dharma* nor its rival. Properly educated, desire becomes one of the principal means through which human beings participate joyfully in the moral order of life.

FIGURE 3. NĀṬYA AS THE AESTHETIC EDUCATION OF KĀMA *From Desire to Character*



Sources: *Nāṭyaśāstra*, Adhyāya 6 (*Rasa–bhāva–abhinaya*); Kapila Vatsyayan, *Classical Indian Dance in Literature and the Arts* (New Delhi: Sangeet Natak Akademi, 1968), pp. 45–68.

⁴⁷ *Nāṭyaśāstra* 6; Kapila Vatsyayan, *Classical Indian Dance in Literature and the Arts* (New Delhi: Sangeet Natak Akademi, 1968).

The transformative potential of aesthetic cultivation finds a close parallel in Sage Patañjali's psychology of disciplined consciousness: योगश्चित्तवृत्तिनिरोधः । (*Yoga is the cessation of the fluctuations of the mind*⁴⁸).

Like Yoga, *Nāṭya* refines the movements of consciousness, not by suppressing emotion, but by transforming it through disciplined aesthetic experience.

4.4. Mokṣa: Inner Freedom as the Highest Expression of Human Flourishing

The culmination of the normative architecture is *Mokṣa*.

Although often interpreted primarily as liberation from the cycle of rebirth, the *Bhagavad Gītā* and *Vedānta* consistently portray liberation as an existential transformation realised within the present life. The liberated person is not defined by withdrawal from the world but by freedom within it.⁴⁹

The *Gītā*'s description of the *sthitaprajña* provides the psychological portrait of such a person. Established in wisdom, one remains steady amidst pleasure and pain, gain and loss, praise and blame. This equanimity is neither passivity nor emotional indifference. Rather, it is freedom from compulsive attachment and ego-centred desire.⁵⁰

Within a theory of human flourishing, *Mokṣa* should therefore be understood not merely as a posthumous destiny but as the highest expression of inner freedom. It represents the progressive liberation of consciousness from ignorance, fear, possessiveness, and the tyranny of compulsive craving.

This understanding is reflected in the classical framework of the four *Āśramas* (stages of life): *Brahmacarya* (the life of disciplined learning), *Gr̥hastha* (the householder's life of responsibility and participation), *Vānaprastha* (the gradual transition towards detachment

⁴⁸ *Yoga Sūtras* 1.2.

⁴⁹ *Bhagavad Gītā* 2.55–72.

⁵⁰ *Ibid.*

and service), and *Sannyāsa* (the life of renunciation and spiritual freedom). Rather than isolating *Mokṣa* from worldly existence, this framework situates the pursuit of inner freedom within the progressive unfolding of a rightly ordered life. *Mokṣa* is thus not merely the culmination of the final *Āśrama* but the horizon towards which the whole of life is gradually directed.⁵¹

Seen in this way, *Mokṣa* does not negate *Artha* or *Kāma* but perfects them. By relativising the ultimate significance of wealth, status, and possession, *Mokṣa* stabilises the ethical authority of *Dharma*. Human dignity no longer depends upon accumulation or achievement but upon the freedom that comes from rightly ordered consciousness. Wealth may still be possessed, yet without possessiveness. Desire may continue, yet without bondage. Action continues, relationships continue, leadership continues, but the ego no longer dominates them.

Human flourishing reaches its fullest expression when outward engagement is united with inward freedom. Within this normative architecture, *Mokṣa* is not the negation of life but its fullest fulfilment.

⁵¹ Patrick Olivelle, *The Āśrama System: The History and Hermeneutics of a Religious Institution* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993), 77–119.

FIGURE 4.

THE ĀŚRAMA FRAMEWORK: *Progressive Integration of the Puruṣārthas*



The four Āśramas represent progressive contexts in which *Dharma*, *Artha*, *Kāma*, and *Mokṣa* are integrated. Within the *Grhastha Āśrama*, this integration is realised through the shared responsibilities of the householder and the *Sahadharminī* (partner in *Dharma*), preparing the ground for the progressive maturation of life towards *Mokṣa* and the fullness of human flourishing.

4.5. The Integration of the *Puruṣārthas*

The originality of the *Puruṣārthas* lies not in the individual concepts themselves but in their integration into a single normative architecture. None of the four can be adequately understood in isolation. Each derives its meaning from its relationship with the others, and above all from the governing orientation provided by *Dharma*.

Rather than representing competing objectives or sequential stages of life, they constitute mutually reinforcing dimensions of a flourishing existence.

- *Dharma* provides moral orientation.
- *Artha* supplies the material conditions necessary for life.
- *Kāma* enriches life through educated desire.
- *Mokṣa* presents the higher telos of human fulfilment, enabling freedom from attachment to finite goods and preventing *Dharma*, *Artha*, and *Kāma* from becoming ends in themselves.

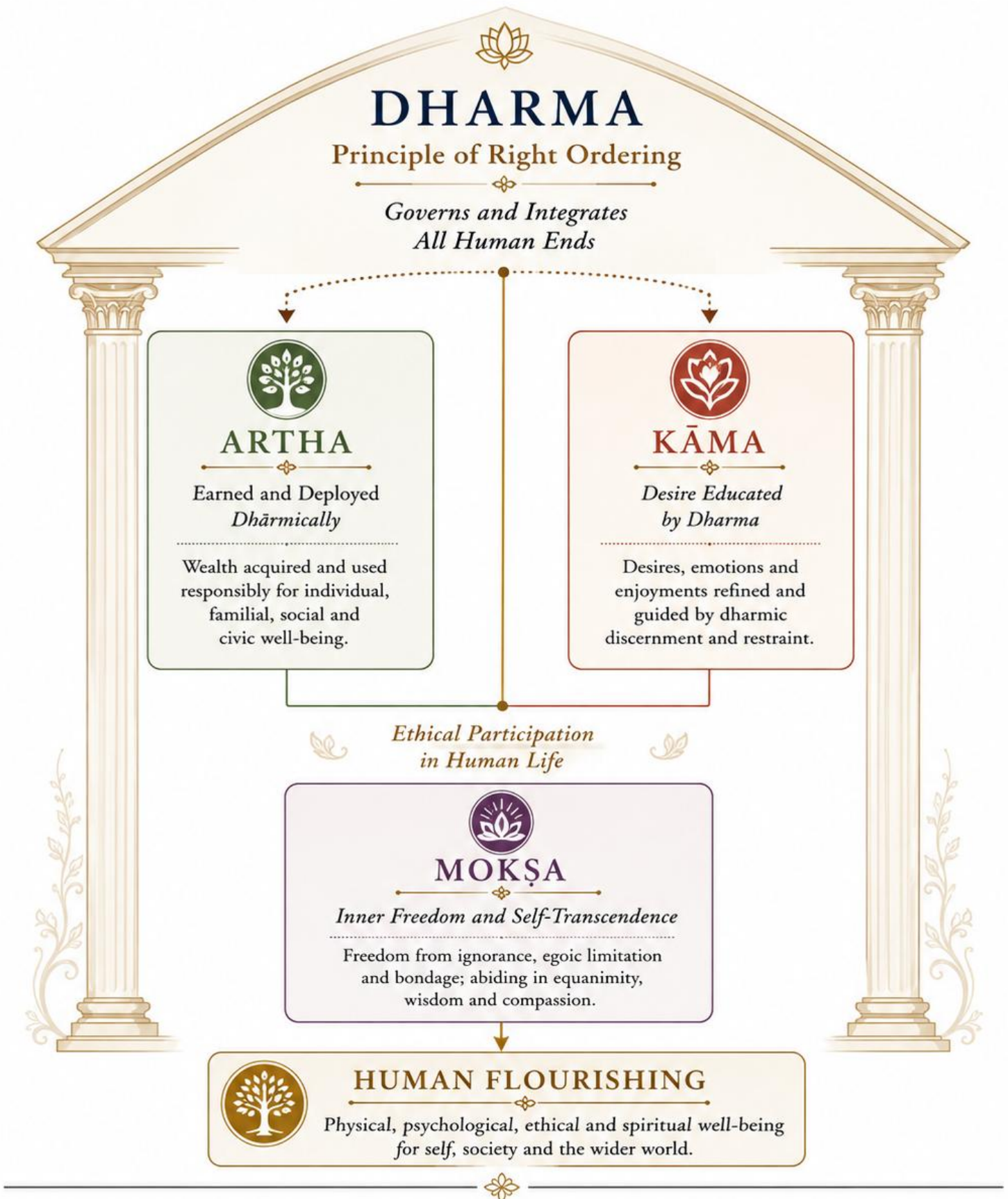
Together they produce an integrated order in which ethical responsibility, material prosperity, emotional fulfilment, aesthetic cultivation, and spiritual freedom become complementary rather than contradictory. The integration of the *Puruṣārthas* also clarifies the distinctive *Dhārmic* conception of spiritual development. Spiritual maturation does not require the rejection of worldly life; rather, it proceeds through the progressive ordering of *Artha* and *Kāma* so that their pursuit remains *Dharma-aviruddha*, not opposed to *Dharma*. Material prosperity and desire may therefore remain fully present within a flourishing life even as consciousness becomes increasingly oriented towards *Mokṣa*. Spiritual development, in the *Dhārmic* sense, is consequently not an escape from the human condition but its progressive reordering towards a higher freedom.⁵²

The *Puruṣārthas* therefore operate not as independent ends but as mutually regulating

⁵² Bhagavad Gītā 7.11; Patrick Olivelle, *The Āśrama System: The History and Hermeneutics of a Religious Institution* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993), 77–119.

dimensions of a single normative order. The originality of this architecture lies in recognising that neither prosperity nor desire is self-justifying. Both acquire legitimacy only when ordered by *Dharma* and ultimately fulfilled in the inner freedom of *Mokṣa*. The *Puruṣārthas* therefore describe not four independent pursuits but a unified moral ecology of human flourishing.

Figure 5: The *Puruṣārthas* as the Normative Architecture of Human Flourishing.



Note: Dharma functions as the governing principle that rightly orders and integrates all human ends. It enables the pursuit and proper use of wealth (Artha), educates desire (Kāma), and culminates in inner freedom (Mokṣa). Human flourishing emerges through the harmonious integration of these interdependent dimensions rather than through their isolated pursuit.

4.6. Towards an Integrated Theory of Human Flourishing

The *Puruṣārthas* offer one of the most sophisticated accounts of the normative architecture of human flourishing. Rather than separating economics from ethics, pleasure from restraint, or spirituality from public life, they integrate these dimensions into a coherent vision of human existence.

As Figure 5 suggests, *Dharma* functions as the governing principle through which *Artha*, *Kāma*, and *Mokṣa* are ordered into a coherent whole. Rather than representing independent or competing objectives, the *Puruṣārthas* operate as mutually reinforcing dimensions of a flourishing life, each deriving its meaning through its relationship with *Dharma*.

This integrated framework provides a compelling alternative to contemporary approaches that frequently isolate material success from moral responsibility, psychological well-being from social obligation, or spiritual aspiration from institutional life. The *Dhārmic* tradition instead insists that flourishing arises through the harmonious ordering of every dimension of human existence.

Dharma orders *Artha*. *Dharma* educates *Kāma*. *Dharma* culminates in *Mokṣa*. Human flourishing therefore consists neither in material success alone nor in renunciation alone, but in the harmonious integration of ethical responsibility, material sufficiency, cultivated desire, and spiritual freedom.

4.7. Normative Contribution to the Dhārmic Theory

This Chapter has developed the normative architecture of *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*. Together, *Dharma*, *Artha*, *Kāma*, and *Mokṣa* explain not merely what human beings seek, but how the diverse ends of human life become integrated into a coherent and flourishing whole. If the preceding Chapter explained how consciousness becomes capable of embodying *Dharma*, the *Puruṣārthas* demonstrate how the aims of human life may be rightly ordered, integrated, and ultimately oriented toward their higher fulfilment.

The following Chapter develops the relational and affective dimension of this architecture

through *Bhakti* and *Rasa*.

5. Bhakti and Rasa: The Relational and Aesthetic Pedagogy of Human Flourishing

The preceding chapters have established the essential components of *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*. Yet one decisive question remains: What transforms rightly ordered action and ethical obligation into joyful participation?

This question points to a dimension that cannot be fully explained through normative ordering alone. Human beings do not flourish merely by knowing what is right or by correctly ordering the ends of life. They must also be affectively transformed, brought into meaningful relationship, and capable of experiencing participation in *Dharma* not merely as obligation but as fulfilment.

Rules may regulate conduct, institutions may organise society, and ethical reasoning may illuminate duty. None of these, however, fully explains how individuals come to willingly transcend narrow self-interest in the service of others. Human flourishing requires not only right order but an interior disposition through which obligation becomes willing participation.

The *Dhārmic* tradition addresses this question through *Bhakti* and aesthetic pedagogy.

The *Taittirīya Upaniṣad* expresses an important metaphysical ground for this conception in the celebrated declaration: रसो वै सः (*Verily, He is Rasa*⁵³). Here, *Rasa* points beyond ordinary pleasure toward the fullness of delight associated with ultimate reality. Within the broader *Dhārmic* architecture developed here, *Bhakti* and the aesthetic pedagogy of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* may therefore be understood as complementary pathways through which the human person is affectively transformed and progressively drawn into participation in a deeper order of being.

⁵³ *Taittirīya Upaniṣad* 2.7.1.

5.1. Bhakti Beyond Religious Emotion

Modern discussions frequently interpret *Bhakti* as emotional religiosity or devotional sentiment. Such interpretations capture only one dimension of a far richer concept.

Within the *Bhagavad Gītā* and the broader *Bhakti* tradition, *Bhakti* signifies an existential orientation characterised by love, trust, self-offering, participation, and unwavering commitment to the Divine. It is fundamentally relational rather than merely emotional. *Bhakti* transforms the relationship between the individual and God, and consequently reshapes relationships with oneself, with others, and with the wider world.⁵⁴

The *Bhagavad Gītā* repeatedly portrays devotion as inseparable from ethical transformation. The qualities of the true devotee are described not primarily in ritual terms but through dispositions of character: अद्वेष्टा सर्वभूतानां मैत्रः करुण एव च। निर्ममो निरहङ्कारः

समदुःखसुखः क्षमी॥ (*One who bears no hatred toward any being, who is friendly and compassionate, free from possessiveness and ego, balanced in pleasure and pain, and forgiving*⁵⁵).

The devotee is recognised not by emotional intensity alone but by humility, compassion, equanimity, forgiveness, and concern for the welfare of all beings. *Bhakti* therefore extends beyond worship into a comprehensive mode of ethical existence.⁵⁶

As Rāmānuja observes in his commentary on the *Bhagavad Gītā*, devotion culminates in loving surrender (*prapatti*), through which every aspect of life becomes oriented toward the Divine. *Bhakti* is thus not an episodic religious practice but a continuous disposition that reorders the whole person.⁵⁷

⁵⁴ *Bhagavad Gītā* 9.22–34; 12.13–20; Karen Pechilis, *The Embodiment of Bhakti* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999), 3–24.

⁵⁵ *Bhagavad Gītā* 12.13–14.

⁵⁶ John Stratton Hawley, *A Storm of Songs: India and the Idea of the Bhakti Movement* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2015), 1–34.

⁵⁷ Rāmānuja, *Gītā Bhāṣya*, commentary on *Bhagavad Gītā* 12.13–20 and 18.66.

5.2. Bhakti and the Transformation of Consciousness

Chapter 3 established the *Triguṇas* as the framework for the cultivation of consciousness. *Bhakti* extends this cultivation into the relational and affective domain, transforming the very centre of human identity.

Whereas *Sattva* illumines the mind, *Bhakti* dissolves the ego. The *Bhagavad Gītā* repeatedly presents devotion as the means through which self-centred existence is gradually replaced by loving participation in a reality greater than oneself. Attachment gives way to surrender, pride to humility, anxiety to trust, and possessiveness to service.⁵⁸

This transformation is not merely psychological but existential. The individual no longer acts primarily for personal gain but participates in the Divine purpose through selfless action.

Śaṅkarācārya interprets devotion as steadfast contemplation of the Supreme Reality that prepares the mind for liberating knowledge. Rāmānuja, by contrast, understands *Bhakti* as loving communion culminating in complete surrender. Despite their theological differences, both traditions recognise that devotion fundamentally transforms the human person.⁵⁹

5.3. Aesthetic Cultivation (Rasa) as Emotional Pedagogy

Human beings rarely act according to abstract principles alone. Desire, imagination, and affect must themselves be educated. A distinctive contribution of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* to a theory of human flourishing lies in recognising that ethical transformation requires emotional formation. The *Nāṭya* tradition therefore complements philosophical instruction by cultivating the emotional dispositions through which *Dharma* becomes not only intelligible but attractive. Through aesthetic experience, moral insight becomes emotionally embodied, preparing the ground for the flowering of *Bhakti*.⁶⁰

⁵⁸ *Bhagavad Gītā* 9.22–34; 12.6–8.

⁵⁹ Ādi Śaṅkarācārya, *Bhagavad Gītā Bhāṣya*, commentary on 12.8–12; Rāmānuja, *Gītā Bhāṣya*, commentary on 12.13–20.

⁶⁰ *Nāṭyaśāstra* 1.107–108; Kapila Vatsyayan, *Classical Indian Dance in Literature and the Arts* (New Delhi: Sangeet Natak Akademi, 1968).

This formative function of *Nāṭya* also opens a dialogue with contemporary developmental theory. Anchil Gaetan Hoareau's *Developmental Coherence Theory* (DCT) proposes that certain developmentally consequential encounters may lead to durable developmental reorganisation through processes of differentiation and integration. Hoareau explicitly recognises cultural practices, narratives, communities, rituals, and spiritual frameworks as possible developmental resources.⁶¹ Within this vocabulary, *Nāṭya* may be understood as a candidate developmental resource through which the performer and the spectator alike encounter, differentiate, integrate, and potentially reorganise patterns of perception, affect, value, and response. This is not to claim that *Nāṭya* instantiates DCT as a demonstrated mechanism, but to identify a potentially testable point of correspondence between aesthetic pedagogy and contemporary theories of human formation.

Seen from this perspective, the movement from *Bhāva* through *Rasa* towards the cultivation of *Sattva* may be regarded as a *Dhārmic* pathway of affective formation. It should not, however, be presented as inherently richer than contemporary psychological constructs. Its significance lies elsewhere: it offers a distinctive civilisational account of how emotion may be aesthetically mediated, refined, and progressively incorporated into a larger process of ethical and spiritual formation. Whether this pathway corresponds to measurable processes of differentiation, integration, and reorganisation remains an empirical question.⁶²

How, then, does consciousness undergo such transformation? Abstract philosophical instruction alone rarely alters human desire or emotional conditioning. The *Dhārmic* tradition addresses this question through the structured cognitive and emotional pedagogy of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*.

Aesthetic pedagogy operates through *Rasa-Siddhānta* (the theory of aesthetic experience). In ordinary life, human emotions (*bhāvas*) are bound to personal ego, attachment, and immediate interest. When the performer embodies and the spectator encounters emotion

⁶¹ Anchil Gaetan Hoareau, *Developmental Coherence Theory and Human Flourishing Theory: A Developmental and Configurational Theory of Meaningful Participation in Finite Human Life*, DCT–HFT Version 1.0, Scholarly Revised Edition (unpublished manuscript, 2026), 48, 55–56.

⁶² *Nāṭyaśāstra*, chap. 6; Abhinavagupta, *Abhinavabhāratī*, commentary on the *Rasa Sūtra*; Anchil Gaetan Hoareau, *Developmental Coherence Theory and Human Flourishing Theory*, 37–38, 100–103.

through artistic representation, however, personal attachment may be transformed through the aesthetic process, allowing experience to become less exclusively private and more universally accessible. The spectator experiences emotion in a universalised rather than merely personal mode, a process that Abhinavagupta later explained through the doctrine of *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa*.⁶³

Through *Rasa*, affective experience is aesthetically mediated and transformed in its mode of apprehension. Experiences such as *śoka* may be encountered through *karuṇa*, *bhaya* through *bhayānaka*, and *rati* through *śṛṅgāra*, while the aesthetic process loosens experience from its immediate personal appropriation. In the *Dhārmic* account developed here, such aesthetic transformation may contribute to the refinement of affect and the progressive cultivation of *Sattva* and *Bhakti*. The *Nāṭyaśāstra* is therefore not merely a manual for performance; it is a civilisational emotional pedagogy. It can therefore be understood as a disciplined pedagogy through which affect may be refined, moral perception cultivated, and consciousness progressively oriented towards *Sattva*, thereby preparing the ground for relational *Bhakti*.

In this sense, the *Nāṭyaśāstra* functions as a sophisticated emotional pedagogy through which desire is refined, empathy cultivated, and consciousness progressively oriented towards *Sattva* and *Bhakti*. Aesthetic experience becomes an instrument of ethical formation rather than mere entertainment. Figure 3 summarises this pedagogical movement from emotion to character through the transformative power of *Rasa*.⁶⁴

5.4. Bhakti and Social Flourishing

The significance of *Bhakti* extends far beyond individual spirituality. Devotion transforms society because it transforms relationships.

Communities rooted solely in law depend upon external enforcement. Communities animated by *Bhakti* generate trust, reciprocity, compassion, and voluntary service. Ethical

⁶³ *Nāṭyaśāstra*, chap. 6 (Rasa Sūtra); Abhinavagupta, *Abhinavabhāratī*, commentary on the Rasa Sūtra, where the doctrine of *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa* is developed.

⁶⁴ Kapila Vatsyayan, *Classical Indian Dance in Literature and the Arts*.

conduct becomes sustained not merely by obligation but by love.

Unlike relationships sustained primarily through reciprocity, contract, or external enforcement, *Bhakti* nurtures relationships grounded in trust, gratitude, and self-giving. These dispositions generate the social capital upon which families, communities, and institutions ultimately depend. Social flourishing therefore emerges not only from just institutions but from transformed relationships.

This insight finds powerful expression across the *Bhakti* traditions of India. The poetry of Ravidas envisions a society free from hierarchy and exclusion. Kabir rejects sectarian divisions in favour of spiritual fraternity. Caitanya Mahāprabhu transforms devotion into communal celebration through *Śaṅkīrtana*. Nārāyaṇa Guru grounds social equality in the recognition of the Divine within every human being.⁶⁵

Bhakti thus becomes the ethical foundation of fraternity. Individuals cease to encounter one another merely as competitors, consumers, or strangers. They increasingly recognise one another as participants in a shared sacred reality.

5.5. *Bhakti* and Civilisational Continuity

The civilisational significance of *Bhakti* lies in its capacity to sustain institutions through shared meaning rather than coercion alone. Civilisations endure not merely because they possess laws, governments, or markets, but because they cultivate relationships of trust that bind successive generations together.

Bhakti has historically animated many of the institutions that preserve India's civilisational continuity: temples, pilgrimage networks, festivals, music, dance, literature, education, charitable service, and community life.⁶⁶ These institutions transmit not merely beliefs but habits of compassion, reverence, generosity, and collective memory.

They do more than preserve inherited traditions; they continually regenerate the ethical

⁶⁵ Winand M. Callewaert and Peter G. Friedlander, trans., *The Life and Works of Ravidas* (New Delhi: Manohar, 1992); Charlotte Vaudeville, *Kabir* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1974); John Stratton Hawley, *A Storm of Songs*; T. Bhaskaran, *Sree Narayana Guru* (New Delhi: National Book Trust, 2007).

⁶⁶ John Stratton Hawley, *A Storm of Songs*, 1–34.

imagination through which civilisation reproduces itself across generations. *Bhakti* therefore sustains not only personal devotion but the civilisational processes through which flourishing is generated, sustained, and transmitted.

5.6. Bhakti as the Integrative Principle

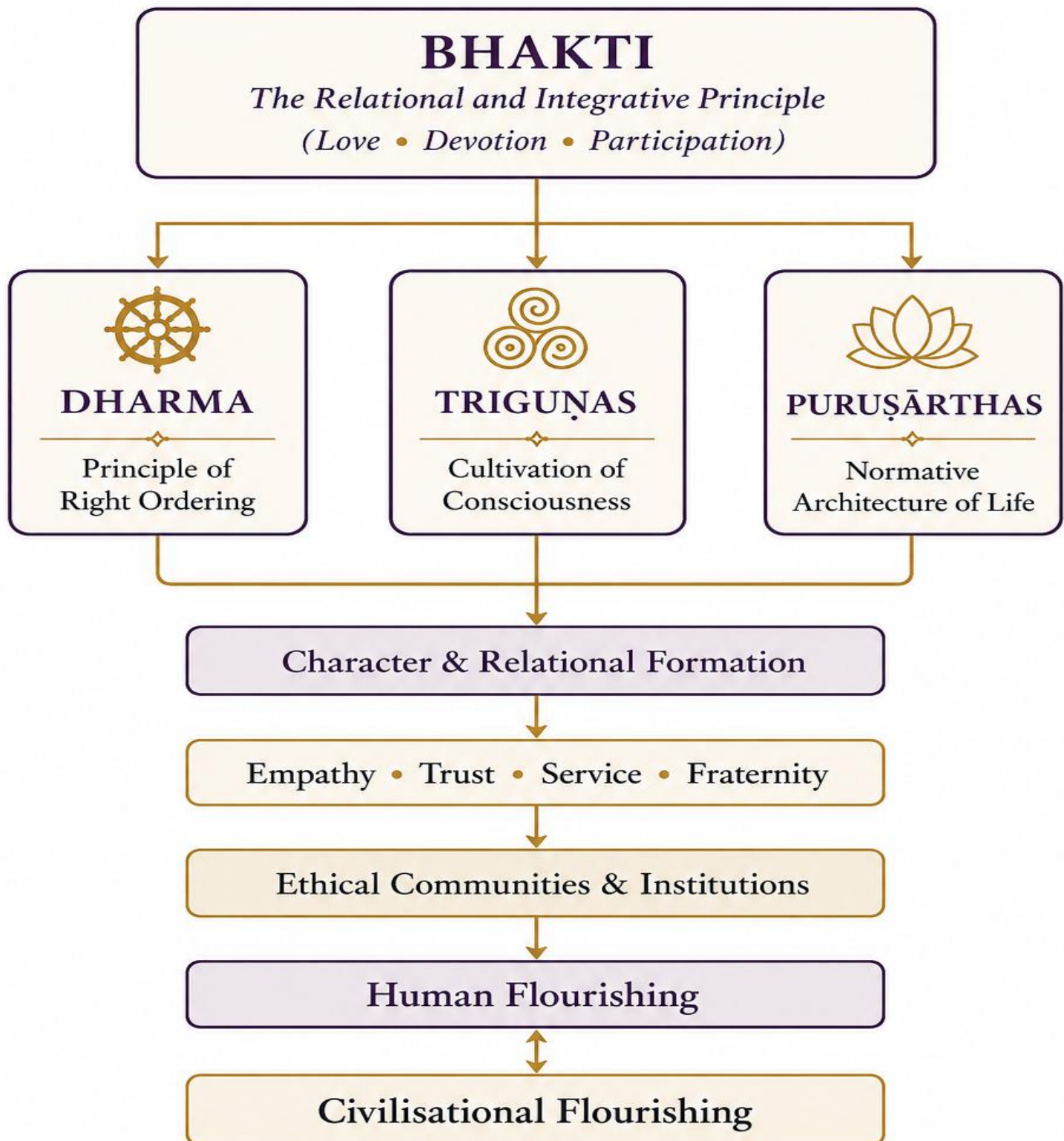
The originality of *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing* developed in this paper lies not merely in bringing together *Dharma*, the *Triguṇas*, the *Puruṣārthas*, and *Bhakti*, but in demonstrating their dynamic integration within a single explanatory framework. While each contributes a distinct dimension of flourishing, their full significance emerges only through their reciprocal interaction.

Figure 4 illustrates this integrative role by placing *Bhakti* in dynamic relationship with *Dharma*, the *Triguṇas*, and the *Puruṣārthas*. Rather than functioning as an isolated component of the framework, *Bhakti* animates the entire architecture by transforming ethical principles into lived relationships, institutions, and communities.

Bhakti performs this integrative function:

- *Dharma* establishes right order.
- The *Triguṇas* cultivate the consciousness capable of perceiving and embodying that order.
- The *Puruṣārthas* organise the diverse dimensions of human life within that order.
- *Bhakti* animates the entire structure by transforming duty into love, discipline into joy, and coexistence into fellowship.

Figure 6. Bhakti as the Relational and Integrative Principle in The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing.



Bhakti animates the ethical orientation provided by Dharma, the cultivation of consciousness through the Trigunās, and the normative ordering of life through the Puruṣārthas. Through the formation of character, relationships, and institutions, it transforms these complementary dimensions into a lived civilisational order of human flourishing. As argued in this chapter, the Nāṭyaśāstra provides one of the principal aesthetic pedagogies through which Bhakti cultivates empathy, emotional refinement, fraternity, and social cohesion.

Human flourishing is not merely a state to be measured but an emergent order to be cultivated. *Bhakti* reveals that this order is sustained not only through ethical principles and disciplined consciousness, but through relationships transformed by love, trust, and shared participation. In this sense, *Bhakti* converts an internally coherent architecture into a lived civilisational practice.

5.7. Relational Contribution to the Dhārmic Theory

The distinctive relational contribution of *Bhakti* lies in transforming the relationship between persons from a matter of duty, coordination, or mutual obligation into one of willing participation and shared belonging. *Dharma* can establish the principles governing right relationship; the *Triguṇas* can cultivate the consciousness required to inhabit those principles; and the *Puruṣārthas* can order the ends pursued within social life. *Bhakti*, however, addresses the affective quality of relationship itself: it makes the other not merely an object of duty or a participant in social exchange, but one toward whom love, reverence, trust, and service can be directed.

This has implications beyond individual devotion. When such dispositions become socially embodied, they can generate forms of fellowship in which cooperation is sustained not solely by rules, incentives, or enforcement, but by a shared sense of belonging and participation in a larger order. *Bhakti* therefore provides a bridge between the interior transformation of the person and the relational life of communities and institutions.

Its contribution to human flourishing is thus not simply that it adds an emotional dimension to an otherwise complete framework. Rather, it helps explain how an ethically and psychologically ordered human being becomes capable of loving participation in an order larger than the self. In this sense, *Bhakti* completes the movement from right order, through cultivated consciousness and integrated human ends, to lived relational participation.

Part IV: Embodied Models of Flourishing

6. Civilisational Case Studies

The preceding chapters have developed *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing* by identifying its normative principle (*Dharma*), its psychology (the cultivation of consciousness through the *Triguṇas*), its architecture (the integrated order of the *Puruṣārthas*), and its relational principle (*Bhakti*). A theoretical framework, however, attains its fullest explanatory power only when it is embodied in lived experience.

The figures examined in this Chapter are presented as civilisational case studies that illuminate enduring dimensions of human flourishing. Each addresses a fundamental human question relating to governance, dignity, freedom, love, equality, or community, and demonstrates how the *Dhārmic* framework can be realised under diverse historical and social conditions..

Methodologically, these figures should not be understood as isolated religious personalities or exceptional saints beyond imitation. They function as analytical case studies that test the explanatory power of the *Dhārmic* framework developed in the preceding chapters. Each demonstrates, under distinct historical conditions, how *Dharma*, cultivated consciousness, the *Puruṣārthas*, and *Bhakti* interact to produce enduring forms of human flourishing.

6.1. Analysis of Exemplars

Each exemplar illustrates a distinct yet complementary configuration of *Dharma*, the cultivation of consciousness through the *Triguṇas*, the normative architecture of the *Puruṣārthas*, and the integrative power of *Bhakti*. Together they demonstrate that *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing* is not merely conceptual but historically embodied.

- **Śrī Rāma (Dharma and Governance):** Represents *Maryādā*, the disciplined observance of *Dharma* within personal, familial, and political life. Governance becomes a form of moral responsibility (*Rāma Rājyam*) where authority exists for the

protection of social order and public welfare.⁶⁷

- **Sant Ravidas (Dignity and Equality):** Offers a vision of *Begumpura*, a community free from fear, exclusion, and oppressive hierarchy. Ravidas grounds human dignity in spiritual equality through *Bhakti*.⁶⁸
- **Kabir (Inner Freedom):** Redirects attention from ritualism to the internal transformation of consciousness, demonstrating that flourishing requires freedom from ego, dogmatism, and divisive identities.⁶⁹
- **The Gopīs (Self-Transcending Love):** Embody complete self-giving without calculation, demonstrating how *Bhakti* transforms desire (*Kāma*) into loving communion and spiritual union.⁷⁰
- **Mīrābāī (Devotion and Courage):** Illustrates the liberating power of personal devotion, providing the inner freedom necessary to act according to conscience while remaining rooted in love.⁷¹
- **Śrī Caitanya (Collective Flourishing):** Transformed *Bhakti* into a shared social practice through *San̄kīrtana*, demonstrating that joy shared through collective remembrance generates social solidarity and trust.⁷²
- **Nārāyaṇa Guru (Spiritual Equality):** United spiritual insight with social reform ('*One caste, one religion, one God for humanity*'), grounding social harmony in the recognition of the Divine within every human being.⁷³
- **Comparative Extensions:** While the foregoing exemplars provide the principal case

⁶⁷ *Vālmīki Rāmāyaṇa*, *Ayodhyākāṇḍa* 2.109–113.

⁶⁸ Winand M. Callewaert and Peter G. Friedlander, trans., *The Life and Works of Ravidas* (New Delhi: Manohar, 1992), 115–122.

⁶⁹ Charlotte Vaudeville, *Kabir* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1974), 109–156; Linda Hess and Shukdev Singh, trans., *The Bijak of Kabir* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2002).

⁷⁰ *Śrīmad Bhāgavata Purāṇa* 10.29–33; Friedhelm Hardy, *Viraha-Bhakti: The Early History of Kṛṣṇa Devotion in South India* (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1983), 1–27.

⁷¹ Nancy M. Martin, *Mirabai* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1999).

⁷² Edward C. Dimock Jr., *The Place of the Hidden Moon: Erotic Mysticism in the Vaiṣṇava-Sahajiyā Cult of Bengal* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1966), 39–72.

⁷³ T. Bhaskaran, *Sree Narayana Guru* (New Delhi: National Book Trust, 2007).

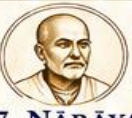
studies for this Chapter, the generative architecture of the *Dhārmic Theory* is equally evident in other figures such as Tukaram (sanctification of ordinary householder life), Basava (ethical labour and institutional equality), Andal (sacred aesthetic devotion), Saint Tyagaraja (*Nāda-Bhakti* and artistic participation), and Svami Vivekananda (Practical *Vedānta* and selfless service). Their inclusion demonstrates the adaptability of the framework across diverse vocations, historical contexts, and modes of life.⁷⁴

Although these exemplars differ in historical context, temperament, and vocation, they exhibit a common generative pattern. Table 1 highlights this shared architecture while preserving the distinctive contribution of each exemplar.

⁷⁴ These figures are included as comparative illustrations of the wider applicability of the *Dhārmic* framework rather than as primary case studies. Their detailed analysis lies beyond the scope of the present paper.

— TABLE 1 —

CIVILISATIONAL EXEMPLARS AS EMBODIED EXPRESSIONS OF THE DHĀRMIC THEORY OF HUMAN FLOURISHING

 EXEMPLAR	 NORMATIVE PRINCIPLE (DHARMA) The ethical–normative orientation of life	 CULTIVATION OF CONSCIOUSNESS (TRIGUṆAS) The dominant mode of cultivated consciousness	 NORMATIVE ARCHITECTURE (PURUṢĀRTHAS) The integrated ordering of life's legitimate ends	 INTEGRATIVE PRINCIPLE (BHAKTI) The relational principle that animates and integrates	 EMERGENT ORDER OF FLOURISHING The civilisational, social and spiritual outcome that emerges
 1. ŚRĪ RĀMA	Maryādā and Righteous Governance	Sattva illumining disciplined Rajas	Artha and Kāma governed by Dharma	Devotion expressed through Public Duty and Selfless Service	Rāma Rājya: Ethical Governance and Institutional Trust
 2. SANT RAVIDAS	Radical Spiritual Equality	Rajas sublimated into Compassionate Service	Social Artha reoriented towards Mokṣa	Ego-dissolving Fraternity rooted in Divine Equality	Begumpura: Inclusive Dignity and Social Justice
 3. KABIR	Truth beyond Sectarian Identity	Sattva transcending Tamasic Ignorance	Direct orientation towards Mokṣa	Nirguṇa Bhakti and Interior Devotion	Premnagar: Universal Love, Spiritual Freedom, and Ego-Transcendence
 4. THE GOPĪS	Complete Surrender to the Divine	Consciousness purified through Self-transcending Love	Kāma transfigured into Divine Love and fulfilled in Mokṣa	Ananya-Bhakti (Exclusive and Unconditional Devotion)	Self-Transcending Love and Spiritual Union
 5. MĪRĀBĀĪ	Fidelity to Conscience and Divine Truth	Courageous and Unwavering Sattva	Artha and Kāma relinquished for Mokṣa	Personal Devotion transcending Social Convention	Interior Freedom Beyond Social Convention
 6. ŚRĪ CAITANYA MAHĀPRABHU	Inclusive Communal Dharma	Emotion refined through Saṅkīrtana into Sattva	Aesthetic Participation oriented towards Mokṣa	Collective Bhakti through Saṅkīrtana	Social Cohesion, Fraternity and Collective Flourishing
 7. NĀRĀYAṆA GURU	Advaita embodied in Social Equality	Tranquil Sattva (Śānta) expressed through Compassionate Action	Artha directed towards Education and Social Uplift	Universal Devotion recognising the Divine in All	Structural Social Harmony and Civilisational Renewal
 8. SAINT TYĀGARĀJA	Music as Sacred Dharma	Sattvic Devotional Consciousness	Kāma refined through Nāda towards Mokṣa	Nāda-Bhakti (Devotion through Sacred Music)	Cultural and Spiritual Renewal through Sacred Music

Note: These exemplars are presented not as biographies but as comparative civilisational case studies. Each embodies a distinctive configuration of Dharma, the Trigūṇas, the Puruṣārthas, and Bhakti, demonstrating how a common generative architecture gives rise to diverse yet complementary forms of individual, social, and civilisational flourishing.

Taken together, these exemplars demonstrate that *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing* is neither confined to a single historical period nor reducible to one mode of life. Rather, it constitutes a generative civilisational framework capable of producing diverse yet recognisably ordered forms of ethical, psychological, relational, institutional, and spiritual flourishing.

6.2. Civilisational Contribution to the Dhārmic Theory

This Chapter has demonstrated that *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing* is not merely a conceptual framework but one that has been embodied across diverse historical lives and civilisational contexts. Through these exemplars, the preceding theoretical architecture is shown to generate distinctive yet complementary forms of ethical, psychological, relational, institutional, and spiritual flourishing. The following Part synthesises these insights into the integrated *Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*.

Part V: Synthesis & Contemporary Dialogue

7. The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing

The preceding chapters have examined the principal dimensions of human flourishing within the *Dhārmic* tradition. Chapter Two established *Dharma* as the normative principle through which human life is rightly ordered. Chapter Three explained the cultivation of consciousness through the *Triguṇas*. Chapter Four presented the *Puruṣārthas* as the normative architecture of flourishing, while Chapter Five identified *Bhakti* and aesthetic pedagogy as the relational and integrative mechanisms. Chapter Six illustrated these principles through embodied case studies.

Considered together, these principles constitute not merely a collection of complementary concepts but a unified generative architecture of human flourishing. Their significance lies less in their individual meanings than in their dynamic interaction, through which ethical order, cultivated consciousness, rightly ordered human ends, and self-transcending

participation become mutually reinforcing dimensions of a flourishing life.

Taken together, these four generative pillars, namely, *Dharma*, the *Triguṇas*, the *Puruṣārthas*, and *Bhakti*, constitute what this paper terms the Four Generative Pillars of *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*. Their significance lies not in their independent operation but in their reciprocal interaction, through which ethical order, cultivated consciousness, rightly ordered human ends, and relational participation become mutually reinforcing dimensions of a flourishing life.

This Chapter synthesises these Four Generative Pillars into *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*, arguing that flourishing is an emergent order arising through their integration into a coherent explanatory framework of human formation and civilisational renewal.

7.1. Dialogue with Modern Empirical Frameworks

Contemporary empirical frameworks, exemplified by Harvard's *Human Flourishing Program*, identify multiple domains associated with flourishing. The *Dhārmic* framework developed in this paper complements these approaches by explaining the generative processes through which such domains may arise and be sustained. Rather than representing independent variables, happiness, health, meaning, virtue, relationships, and material stability emerge as mutually reinforcing expressions of an integrated person living within an integrated civilisational order.⁷⁵

Figure 7 summarises the dialogue between contemporary empirical domains of flourishing and the generative architecture proposed by DTHF. The significance of this comparison lies not in establishing equivalence between the two frameworks but in demonstrating their complementarity. Contemporary flourishing research identifies empirically observable domains associated with flourishing. The *Dhārmic* framework complements these findings by identifying the ethical, psychological, relational, institutional, and spiritual processes through which such dimensions may be cultivated and sustained.

⁷⁵ Tyler J. VanderWeele, *Human Flourishing: An Introductory Framework* (Cambridge, MA: Human Flourishing Program, Harvard Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Harvard University, n.d.).

The relationship is therefore explanatory rather than competitive: empirical observation identifies dimensions in which flourishing becomes observable, while the *Dhārmic* tradition offers an account of the generative conditions through which such flourishing is cultivated and sustained. In doing so, it shifts the analytical focus from describing flourishing to understanding the architecture through which it emerges.

A further contemporary point of dialogue is offered by Hoareau's *Developmental Coherence Theory* and *Human Flourishing Theory* (DCT–HFT). DCT distinguishes developmental reorganisation from flourishing: durable change in a person's organisation is not necessarily an improvement, and developmental change may remain direction-neutral. HFT, meanwhile, proposes a relational and configurational account of flourishing expressed through relations among Reality, Self, Action, Others, and Value, with Meaningful Participation as a central expression.⁷⁶ The distinction is important for the present theory because DTHF does not treat formation as normatively neutral. Developmental processes matter, but their significance ultimately depends upon their direction: whether consciousness, conduct, relationships, institutions, and human aspirations become increasingly aligned with *Dharma* and thereby oriented towards *Śreyas*.

This dialogue also raises a further theoretical question. Contemporary configurational approaches ask whether flourishing depends less upon maximising individual attributes than upon the manner in which different dimensions are organised in relation to one another. DCT–HFT formulates this provisionally through the idea of Dynamic Proportionality.⁷⁷ The *Dhārmic* tradition approaches a related problem through *Dharma* as the principle of order, proportion, relation, and appropriate direction. The comparison therefore invites inquiry into whether the *Dhārmic* conception of flourishing may be understood not as the maximisation of discrete goods, but as a rightly ordered configuration in which ethical, material, relational, psychological, and spiritual dimensions mutually sustain one another.

The comparison should nevertheless remain methodological rather than assimilative. DCT–

⁷⁶ Hoareau, *Developmental Coherence Theory and Human Flourishing Theory*, 3–4

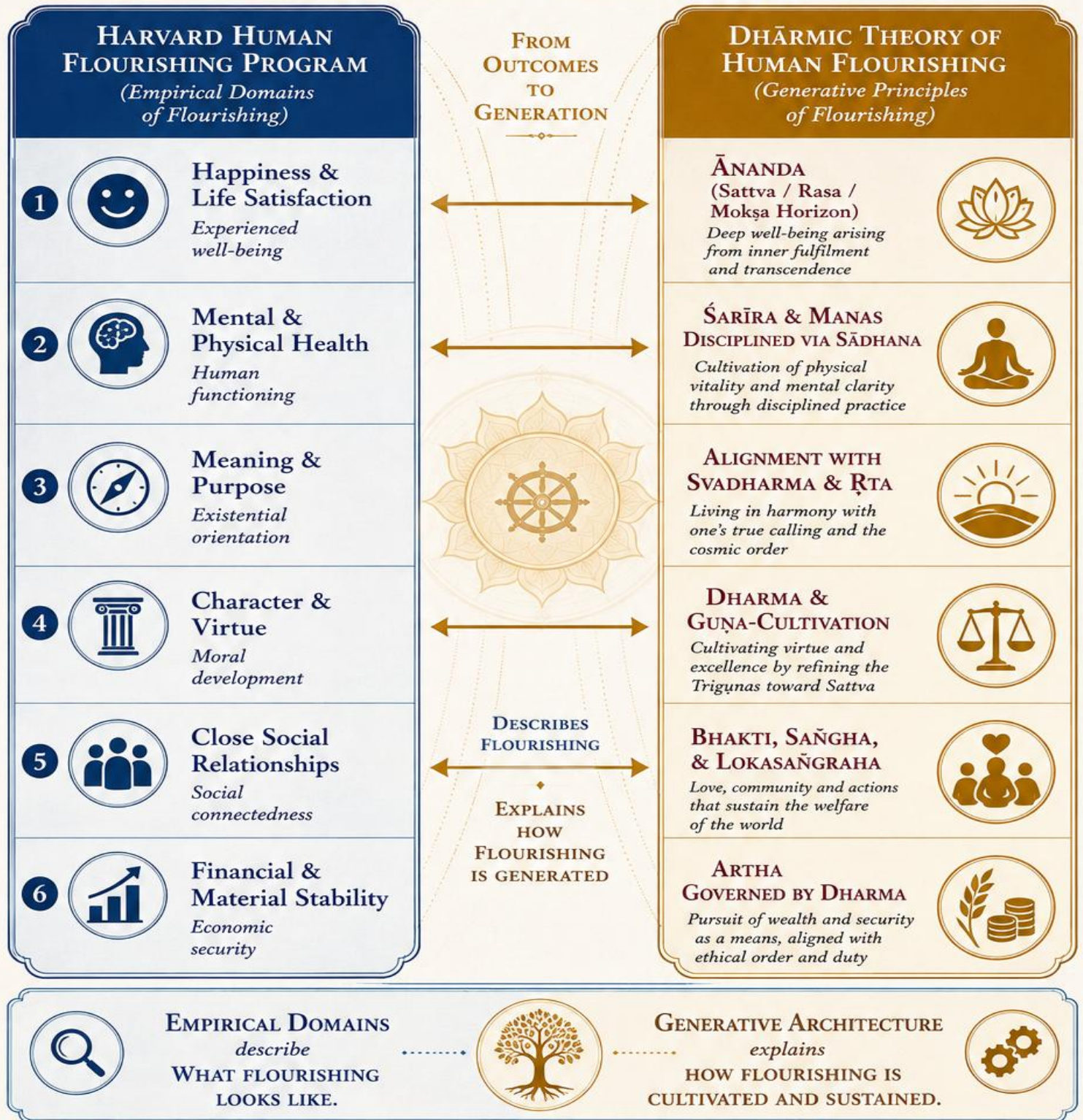
⁷⁷ Hoareau, *Developmental Coherence Theory and Human Flourishing Theory*, 99–103.

HFT presents its constructs as provisional hypotheses open to empirical criticism, revision, and possible falsification; it does not claim to establish a complete philosophy of the good life.⁷⁸ The *Dhārmic* framework, by contrast, is explicitly normative and civilisational. Its claim is not simply that certain configurations correlate with desirable outcomes, but that flourishing depends upon the progressive alignment of human life with *Dharma*. The value of the dialogue therefore lies precisely in preserving the difference between an empirical vocabulary for investigating processes of human reorganisation and a normative account of the direction and meaning of flourishing.

⁷⁸ Hoareau, *Developmental Coherence Theory and Human Flourishing Theory*, 1–4.

CONTEMPORARY EMPIRICAL DOMAINS AND THE DHĀRMIC GENERATIVE ARCHITECTURE OF HUMAN FLOURISHING

From Outcomes to Generative Principles



NOTE

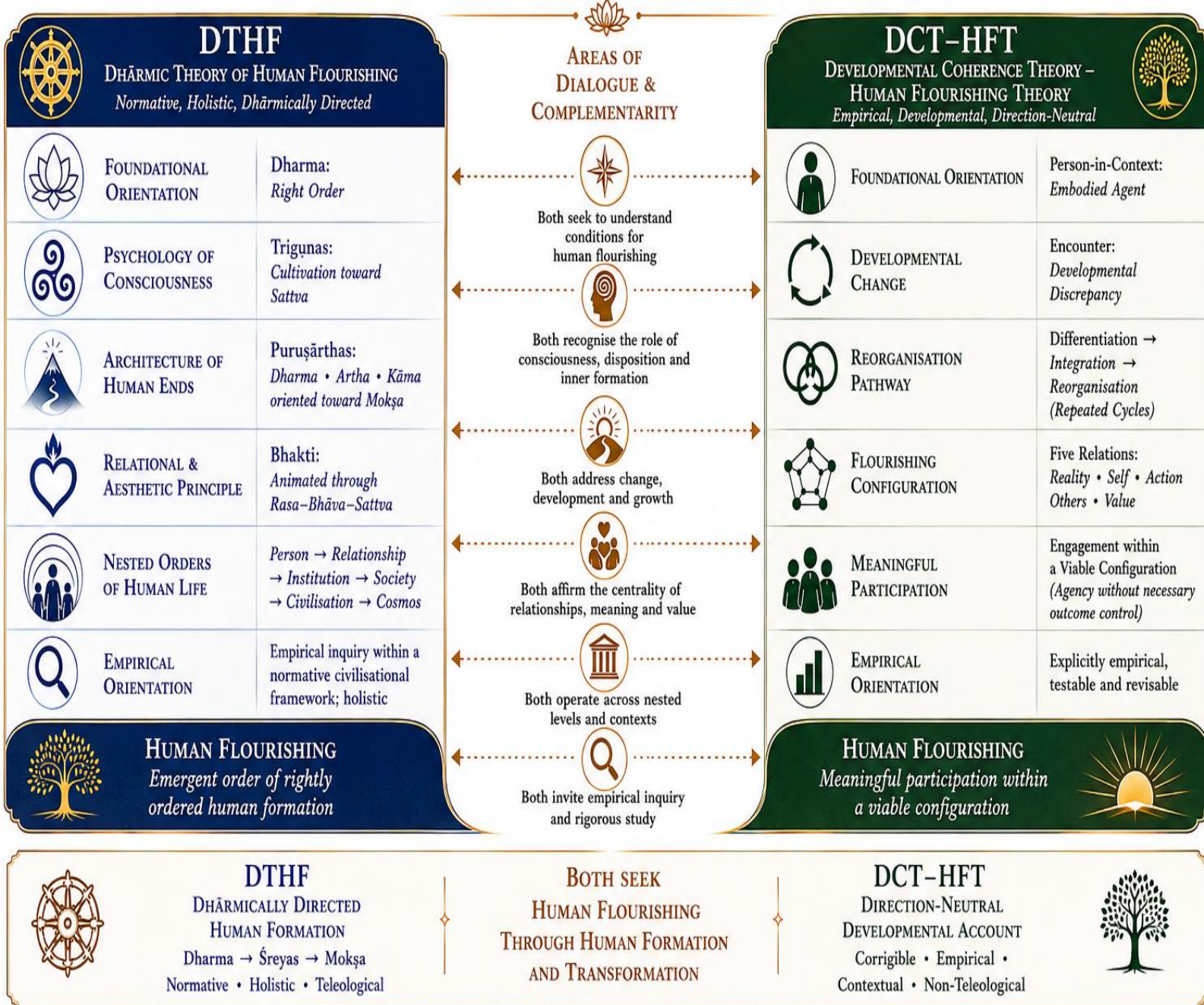
The Harvard Human Flourishing Program identifies empirically observable domains associated with flourishing. The Dhārmic framework does not replace these domains but complements them by identifying the ethical, psychological, relational, and spiritual principles through which such forms of flourishing are generated and sustained. Together, they provide a comprehensive understanding of both the *what* and the *how* of human flourishing.

The dialogue with contemporary flourishing research can be further deepened through comparison with *Developmental Coherence Theory* and *Human Flourishing Theory* (DCT-HFT), whose account of developmental reorganisation and configurational flourishing offers a complementary empirical vocabulary while differing fundamentally from DTHF in normative orientation and ultimate telos.

—→ FIGURE 8 —→

DTHF AND DCT-HFT

A COMPARATIVE ARCHITECTURE OF HUMAN FLOURISHING



Two architectures in dialogue — complementary in inquiry, distinct in orientation.

7.2. The Five Nested Orders of Human Flourishing

The integrated framework developed in this paper may be understood as five nested and mutually reinforcing orders of flourishing. Each order presupposes and strengthens the others, producing flourishing that extends from the formation of the individual to the renewal of civilisation.

1. **Ethical Order:** *Dharma* establishes the normative orientation that prevents power, wealth, and desire from becoming destructive.
2. **Psychological Order:** The doctrine of the *Triguṇas* explains how *Sattva* is cultivated, *Rajas* ethically directed, and *Tamas* progressively reduced, thereby forming the inward dispositions necessary for flourishing.
3. **Relational Order:** *Bhakti* transforms self-interest into participation, dissolves ego, strengthens fraternity, and cultivates compassion, trust, forgiveness, and service.
4. **Institutional Order:** Families, education, governance, economic life, and cultural institutions embody the normative architecture of the *Puruṣārthas*, translating ethical formation into enduring social order.
5. **Civilisational Order:** Shared narratives, aesthetic traditions (*Nāṭya*), pilgrimage, music, education, and institutions of cultural memory transmit *Dharma* across generations, enabling the continuous renewal of civilisational life.

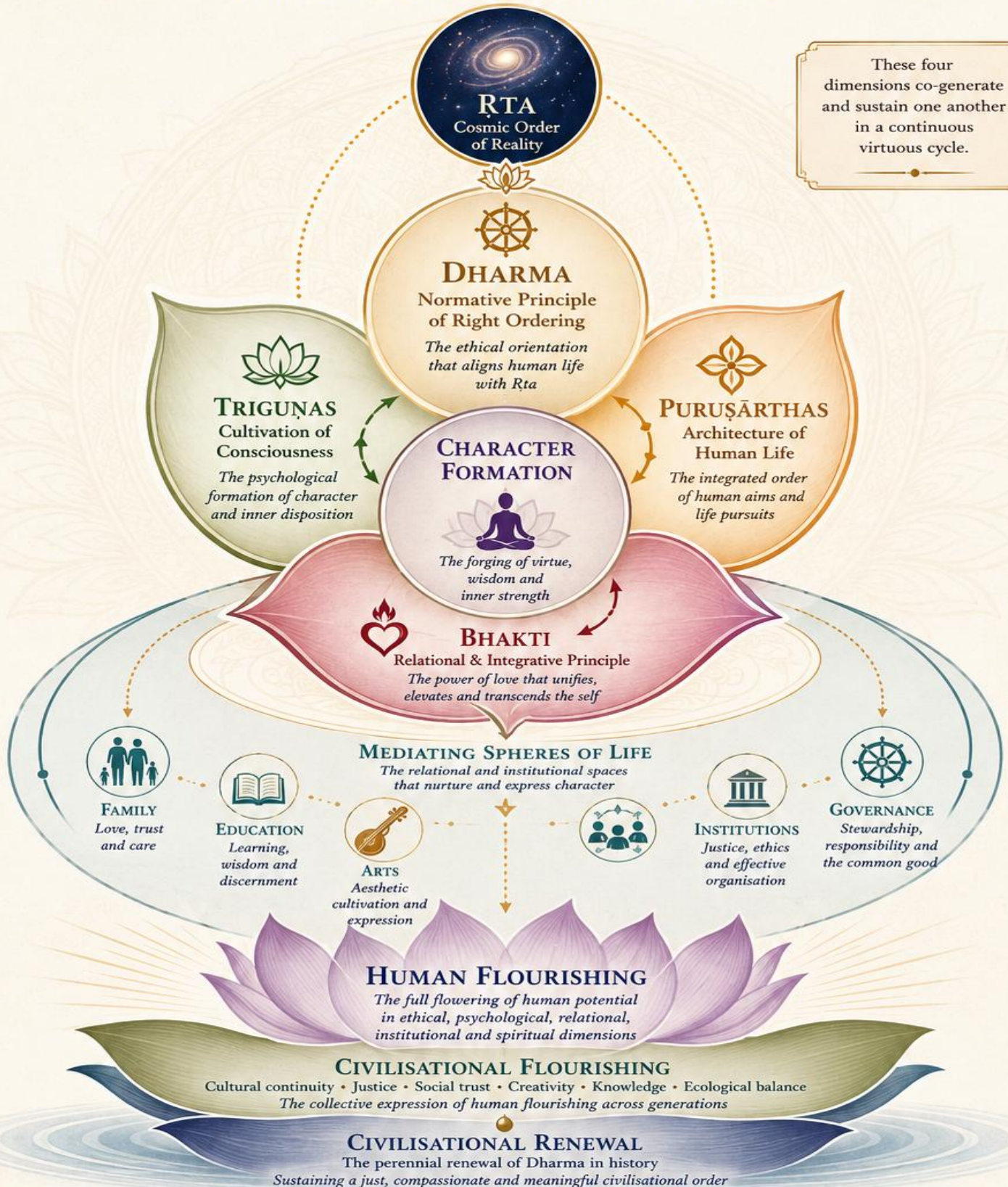
Taken together, these five nested orders represent the social and civilisational expression of the Four Generative Pillars developed throughout this paper. What begins as the ethical formation of the individual culminates in the renewal of civilisation itself. The nested structure also suggests that flourishing should not be understood as the maximisation of any single domain. Its character lies in the quality of the relationships among these orders and in their progressive alignment with *Dharma*. In this respect, the *Dhārmic* account converges with contemporary configurational approaches in shifting attention from isolated attributes towards the organisation of the whole, while retaining a distinctive normative direction.⁷⁹

⁷⁹ Hoareau, *Developmental Coherence Theory and Human Flourishing Theory*, 99–103.

THE INTEGRATED GENERATIVE ARCHITECTURE OF THE DHĀRMIC THEORY OF HUMAN FLOURISHING

From Cosmic Order to Civilisational Renewal

These four dimensions co-generate and sustain one another in a continuous virtuous cycle.



NOTE

This figure synthesises the argument developed throughout the paper. Human flourishing is presented not as the product of any single principle but as an emergent order generated through the dynamic interaction of Dharma (normative orientation), the Trigūṇas (cultivation of consciousness), the Puruṣārthas (the integrated architecture of human ends), and Bhakti (the relational and integrative principle). Through the formation of character and the mediating institutions of family, education, the arts, community, and governance, these dimensions generate both individual flourishing and enduring civilisational renewal.

7.3. Toward an Integrated Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing

This Chapter has synthesised the philosophical, psychological, ethical, relational, institutional, and civilisational dimensions developed throughout the paper into *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*. It demonstrates that flourishing is not produced by isolated virtues or outcomes but emerges through the dynamic interaction of *Dharma*, the cultivation of consciousness through the *Triguṇas*, the normative architecture of the *Puruṣārthas*, and the integrative power of *Bhakti*.

Together, these constitute a coherent generative architecture through which human flourishing is cultivated, sustained, and transmitted across generations.

The framework also opens a programme of empirical inquiry. The propositions advanced here should not be treated as empirically established merely because they are philosophically coherent or historically embodied. One promising line of investigation would examine whether sustained engagement with *Dhārmic* formative practices, including *Nāṭya*, is associated over time with measurable changes in emotional regulation, ethical dispositions, relational capacity, meaning and purpose, and other established indicators of flourishing. Such inquiry would be particularly valuable if designed longitudinally, with repeated measurement of the same individuals across meaningful periods of practice and participation. The purpose would not be to force classical categories such as *Rasa*, *Bhāva*, *Sattva*, *Dharma*, or *Bhakti* into predetermined psychological scales, but to investigate whether the processes they describe correspond to observable patterns of human formation and flourishing.⁸⁰

8. Conclusion

The central question guiding this paper has been deceptively simple: How does human flourishing arise?

Contemporary scholarship has made remarkable progress in identifying the conditions

⁸⁰ Hoareau, *Developmental Coherence Theory and Human Flourishing Theory*, 100–103, 125.

associated with flourishing.⁸¹ Research in Positive Psychology has illuminated the importance of meaning, resilience, positive relationships, and character strengths. The Capability Approach has demonstrated that genuine well-being depends upon substantive human freedoms rather than material resources alone.⁸² Multidimensional measures of development have further broadened public understanding by recognising health, education, social participation, and environmental quality as integral components of a flourishing life.

These contributions have substantially enriched contemporary understandings of human well-being. Yet they also invite a complementary question: If flourishing is multidimensional, what enables these diverse dimensions to become integrated within the life of the individual and the community?

This paper has argued that the *Dhārmic* tradition offers a distinctive response. It explains flourishing not by beginning with its observable outcomes, but by identifying the generative principles through which those outcomes emerge. Rather than beginning with outcomes, it begins with order. Flourishing emerges through the progressive ordering of the self, relationships, institutions, and civilisation according to *Dharma*. Ethical conduct is sustained by the cultivation of consciousness through the *Triguṇas*. Human aspirations are harmonised through the integrated architecture of the *Puruṣārthas*. *Bhakti* and aesthetic pedagogy transform this architecture into lived reality by cultivating love, trust, participation, and self-transcending service.

The result is a conception of flourishing that is simultaneously ethical, psychological, relational, institutional, and civilisational. These are not discrete domains but mutually reinforcing orders of human existence, each sustaining the others within an integrated architecture of flourishing. Human flourishing is therefore not reducible to subjective happiness, material prosperity, institutional effectiveness, or spiritual fulfilment

⁸¹ Martin E. P. Seligman, *Flourish* (New York: Free Press, 2011); Martha C. Nussbaum, *Creating Capabilities: The Human Development Approach* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2011); Tyler J. VanderWeele, *Human Flourishing: An Introductory Framework* (Cambridge, MA: Human Flourishing Program, Harvard Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Harvard University, n.d.).

⁸² Martha C. Nussbaum, *Creating Capabilities: The Human Development Approach* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2011).

considered in isolation. It emerges from their harmonious integration.

The principal theoretical contribution of this paper has been to synthesise these classical concepts into a coherent explanatory framework: *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*. This framework proposes that flourishing is an emergent property of rightly ordered human life, arising through the dynamic interaction of *Dharma*, cultivated consciousness, the integrated pursuit of the *Puruṣārthas*, and the relational power of *Bhakti*. In doing so, it seeks not to replace contemporary theories of flourishing but to complement them by offering a civilisational account of the processes through which flourishing is generated, cultivated, sustained, and transmitted across generations.

The argument developed throughout this paper may therefore be expressed in a single proposition: *human flourishing is not merely a state to be measured but an emergent order to be cultivated*. Prosperity, happiness, resilience, institutional trust, and social cohesion are not independent objectives to be pursued in isolation. They are the natural fruits of the progressive ordering of consciousness, conduct, relationships, institutions, and civilisation according to *Dharma*.

The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing developed in this paper proposes that the good life is neither an individual achievement nor merely a social outcome. It is the progressive realisation of right order within the self, among persons, through institutions, and across civilisation. By bringing the ethical, psychological, relational, institutional, and civilisational dimensions of flourishing into a unified generative framework, this theory contributes not merely an alternative account of well-being but a comprehensive civilisational explanation of how flourishing is generated, cultivated, sustained, and transmitted across generations.

In an age increasingly concerned with measuring the quality of human life, the *Dhārmic* tradition reminds us that the deepest task is not merely to measure flourishing, but to cultivate the right order from which flourishing naturally emerges. The true measure of a civilisation therefore lies not only in the prosperity it achieves, but in the kind of human beings it forms.

This proposition also remains open to empirical examination. *The Dhārmic Theory of*

Human Flourishing therefore invites a research programme in which philosophical claims about human formation are placed in dialogue with longitudinal evidence concerning how consciousness, conduct, relationships, participation, and flourishing change over time. Such inquiry may reveal where the *Dhārmic* framework converges with established psychological constructs, where it offers distinctive explanatory possibilities, and where its claims require revision. Its aspiration is not immunity from empirical scrutiny, but a deeper dialogue between civilisational knowledge and contemporary inquiry.
